Olivier Messiaen • Yvonne Loriod-Messiaen

RAVEL

ANALYSES OF THE PIANO WORKS OF MAURICE RAVEL

by Olivier Messiaen
and Yvonne Loriod-Messiaen

English translation Paul Griffiths

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PREFACE

All through his life Messiaen taught, discussed and analysed the music of Maurice Ravel, particularly those great masterpieces for the piano *Ma Mère l'Oye*, *Gaspard de la Nuit* and *Le Tombeau de Couperin*.

I myself benefited from Messiaen's analyses when I was a pupil in his class at the Paris Conservatoire; many analytical notes figure on his personal scores. I have thereby reconstituted, completed and edited Messiaen's analyses, especially for some of the movements of *Le Tombeau de Couperin*.

Hence is at last this little volume of dialogue between two of the greatest geniuses of French music.

Yvonne Loriod-Messiaen
June 2003

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

This book tells us a lot about Ravel but of course about Messiaen too – not least about his humility in devoting so much care and attention to music other than his own, and about his capacities for admiration and delight. Many of the connections he makes are fascinating – with Chopin, for instance, rather than the more expected (and here unmentioned) Liszt. He also locates Ravel's music, and implicitly his own, in a French tradition that includes – alongside the masters familiar from his other writings and interviews: Debussy, Dukas, Rameau – Massenet, Franck, Fauré and Bizet. In approaching this music in his own way – with reference to his special technical means ('modes of limited transpositions', rhythmic cells, and even 'interversions', by which elements in a cell change places according to a rule), to his love for the fabulous, whether found in fairytale or in opera, and to his greater love for the message of the gospels – he offers a magnifying glass that will enlarge Ravel for all of us.

Paul Griffiths
Lucerne, August 2004

MA MÈRE L'OYE

(Mother Goose)

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MA MÈRE L'OYE

(Mother Goose)

by Maurice Ravel

Analysis by Olivier Messiaen
after his piano score

1. Pavane de la Belle au bois dormant

(Sleeping Beauty's Pavane)

Summary of the form:

Theme: antecedent (4 bars)
Theme: consequent (4 bars)
Commentary (4 bars)
Theme: antecedent (4 bars)
Theme: consequent (4 bars)

The melody is in Chinese pentatonic mode, comprising an arpeggio followed by two seconds, one descending, the other rising.



Figure repeated. The conclusion has two descending fourths:



The counterpoint in the first bar is also in Chinese pentatonic mode, and recalls Grieg on account of its descending sixth:



At bar 5 the consequent is composed of a second and a fourth, descending then rising, as in a mirror.

Double pedal: E in the bass, D in the middle register, with a chromatic counterpoint-embroidery.

The commentary, at bar 9, maintains the seconds and fourths, which Ravel uses again in the *Prelude* of *Le Tombeau de Couperin*.

The repeat of the antecedent, at bar 13, arrives over a pedal consisting of a ninth chord in D with lowered third – a sort of fourth degree of the continuing mode of A with G♮. The consequent has an E pedal.

2. Petit Poucet (Tom Thumb): three periods, framed by the path...

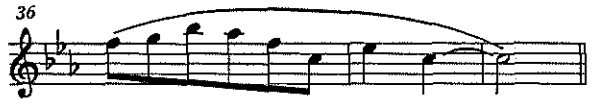
The beginning establishes the scene: the path going on. At first there are three thirds, then seven, then eight, then ten, with the melody entering on the eighth of these, its first period in C minor.

Oboe solo in Ravel's orchestration, harmonized only with thirds. (Chinese pentatonic modes and plainchant modes.) The path – a way like a ribbon, monotonous and endless – supports the melody, which consists largely of seconds, whereas the second period (in E♭ major), beginning at bar 12, includes thirds and wider intervals.

The third period begins at bar 23 and is constructed on a C

minor dominant pedal: G. The melody is similar to the first period, but the thirds of the path have become chromatic.

False recapitulation at bar 33 in C minor, replacing the first period, but the melody here is doubled at the octave. Observe the melodic turn in Chinese pentatonic mode at bars 36-37.



The second period returns in A♭, in the middle register, starting at bar 40.

The third period's reprise is on a G minor dominant pedal. Ravel, living in Montfort-l'Amaury, must have heard numerous bird songs. Here he alludes only to some very short sparrow cries, then to the familiar cuckoo, while the melody proceeds before ascending towards the recapitulation, at bar 60, which restores the first period in C minor, sung in Ravel's orchestration by the two divergent voices of piccolo and cello.

Bar 67 introduces a ninth chord on F with lowered third and a Franckian chromaticism, giving a swaying accompaniment to the fifths of the melody: G-C, then D-G (D the irregular appoggiatura to G), which Ravel later comes to sign with his favourite intervals of second and fourth:



Then the path goes on again in its sad monotony, like a landscape with no end. The start of the theme takes on the light of a C major chord in the last bar, and the major third at last puts a smile on Tom Thumb's face...

3. Laideronnette, impératrice des pagodes

(Laideronnette, Empress of the Pagodas)

Summary of the form:

Movement in three parts, in F♯ major and Chinese pentatonic mode.

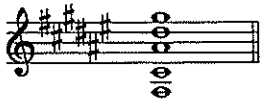
1) First part: Background – First period A1 – Second period A2 – Period B – Period C – First theme –

2) Middle section: New theme – First and second commentaries –

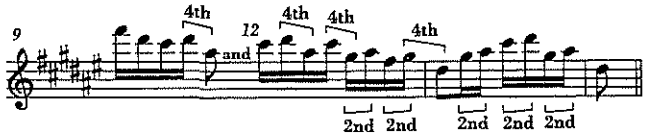
3) Recapitulation, combination of the two themes.

First part

Background, in clashing seconds on a Chinese pentatonic mode which at first is defective, lacking the F♯ and so giving the chord:



The theme of the first period A1, which moves towards the tonic, includes many descending fourths and rising seconds (Chinese pentatonic mode) – see also Florent Schmitt's *Le Petit Elfe Ferme-l'œil* (The Little Elf Shut-Eye):



Closing the first period comes this attractive melodic turn:



At bar 13 the chord is $\frac{7}{+}$ with the tonic affirming the tonality – the B is a note foreign to the Chinese mode (see the opening of Bizet's *Carmen*).

(Chopin's Etude in G♭ major Op. 10 No. 5 provides an example where, by analysing the right-hand melodic turns in groups of four or five notes, one can come up with a selection of the most attractive possible figures, among which are most of those found in plainsong. I have often advised my pupils to make themselves a melodic dictionary they can study, extend, use to find in it their sap and their style. Same thing for a rhythmic dictionary.)

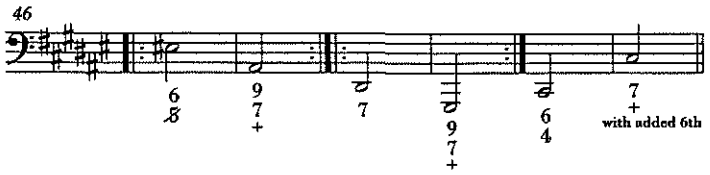
Period A2, moving towards the dominant, begins on the second beat of bar 16. At bar 25 comes a percussion effect made by clashes of two seconds in the high register.

Period B starts at bar 32 and is in C♯ minor with A♯ (the Dorian mode of plainsong). It modulates to B major, then moves marchwise on $\frac{7}{+}$. At bar 32 the chords are:



The B major at bar 38 is opposed by the whole-tone scale at bar 40 (which again contains clashing seconds). This opposition, between the whole-tone scale and a major key, is always present in Debussy where he evokes night then light (see the scene of ascending from the cellars in *Pelléas*).

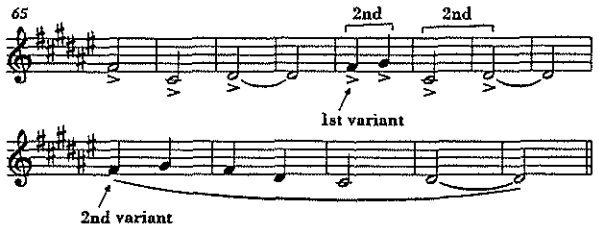
At bar 46 comes the Franckian touch of a chromatic motif in an inner part (see the same motif in the first movement at bar 5), with middle-register embroidery over the chords of this passage:



Period C begins at bar 56. Ravel's orchestration has high xylophone combined with pizzicatos in the middle register. The tonality is F♯ with E♮ (the Mixolydian mode of plainsong). The crescendo leads to the middle section.

Middle section

This begins at bar 65, still in Chinese pentatonic mode, with a new theme:



This is followed by its first commentary, at bar 79 in the bass (the chalumeau register of the clarinet) with an extended melodic turn (six crotchets). Then the theme is replayed at bar 89, but in canon[1].

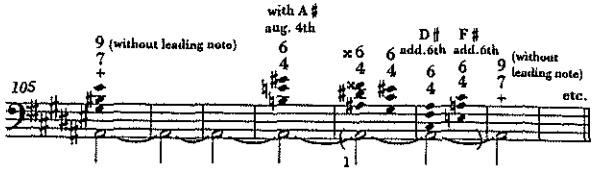
The second commentary, at bar 105, has a new melody, still in the same Chinese mode, with the melodic turn of the *Pavane* (first movement) reconfigured:



There is a D♯ minor dominant pedal (A♯) and, in the middle, parallel $\frac{6}{4}$ chords independent of the Chinese mode.

1) Between clarinet and celesta in Ravel's orchestration.

Chords :



This commentary ends with the start of the theme, at bar 131, which brings back the first commentary in the same low register, underneath the recapitulation.

Recapitulation

From bar 133 the two themes are combined, those of the first part and the middle section (the first part being repeated complete).

At bar 145 comes the first variant of the middle section's theme (see bar 69).

A melodic turn starting at bar 149 combines the second variant of the middle section's theme (see bar 73) with the fall through a fourth from the first theme (see its conclusion in bar 23). The music from bar 24 onwards is repeated to the end, where four chords appear, containing all the notes of the Chinese mode and so forming a major triad with added sixth and ninth (see *Pelléas*).

4. Les Entretiens de la Belle et de la Bête

(The Dialogue of Beauty and the Beast)

In the guise of fairy stories and fables the great poets tell the consoling truths of Faith: is it possible for a monster to

1) The sustained A♯ in bars 109-110 is present in Ravel's orchestration but not in the four-hand piano version.

become good, for a hairy, hideous beast to become a beautiful young man, for a murderer to become a saint?

Yes, Ravel replies, thanks to Love.

And this wonderful piece illustrates the miracle: the theme of the Beast, low and grotesque, transforms itself into the theme of the Prince, in the treble, full of charm and tenderness, the two themes of Beauty and the Beast uniting in a love duet of exquisite transparency, lifting into the skies, in the manner of Marc Chagall's lovers.

Summary of the form:

1) Theme of Beauty, first and second commentaries.
2) Middle section: theme of the Beast. Development on the themes of Beauty and the Beast together.
3) Recapitulation: development and despair of the Beast, as also of Beauty.
4) Coda: the loving dialogue of Beauty and the Prince.

The piece is a waltz, at moderate tempo. This three-beat rhythm haunted Ravel, author of the *Valses nobles et sentimentales*, into which he poured all his harmonic knowledge, and of *La Valse* for orchestra, where rhythmic structures are analysed and juxtaposed up to the final whirlwind.

1) Theme of Beauty, in F major[1]. Eight bars.

At bar 9 begins the **first commentary**, of eight bars, with expansion of intervals: third, fourth, sixth and descending leap of a seventh. Interrupted repetition.

One thinks of Massenet's *Manon* – and of *Pelléas* where the melodic motifs are concerned, and of Massenet again for the 7 and $\frac{9}{7}_{+}$ chords with added sixth.

1) Clarinet solo in Ravel's orchestration

Bar 17: $\frac{9}{7}_{+}$ with altered third (B♭). Bar 18: linkage by augmented fourth. Bars 22-23 move towards the $\frac{7}{+}$ of the principal key with alterations: F♯, G♯, B♮.

The theme returns at bar 24.

The **second commentary**, at bar 31, is a melodic expansion of the preceding effect (bars 9 and on).

Nine bars starting with a pedal of A $\frac{9}{7}_{+}$ with lowered third.

Bar 40: nine bars moving towards C major, the dominant, and a pause.

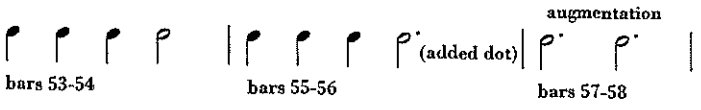
2) Middle section: theme of the Beast (twice) in the extreme bass, a chromatic grunting played on double bassoon in the orchestral version, with a skeletal pulsing of seconds in the whole-tone scale. An unusual interval in Ravel – the descending major seventh E♭, E♮ of bars 52-53 recalls Schönberg.

The E♮ is held as a pedal. Above it is music in the second 'mode of limited transpositions'[1]:



And always the clashing seconds, this time linked seconds.

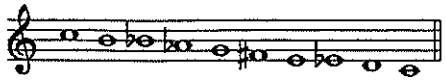
Rhythm:



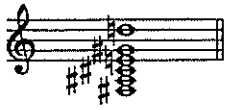
On its second appearance the theme of the Beast is played a tone higher (again with skeletal crotchets, here enriched but still in the whole-tone scale).

1) See Olivier Messiaen: *Traité de rythme, de couleur et d'ornithologie*, Vol.7, Paris, Alphonse Leduc, 2002

The F♯ is held as a pedal, this time underlying music in the third 'mode of limited transpositions':



At bar 69 begins a development on the Beauty and Beast themes together, at first over the low F♯ pedal. The chord is a major ninth with added minor sixth (as at the start of *Ondine*).



Beauty's theme[1] is punctuated by groans in thirds separated by silences. Allusion to the thirds of *Petit Poucet* and to Beauty's despair?

The theme of the Beast[2] begins with a great stepwise rise on the triplet. It is important to note that this theme is in contrary motion to Beauty's. The tempo gets livelier. At bar 85 comes a motif taken from the commentary on the first theme (see bar 17). It is reduced by a process of elimination from bar 93 until just two notes are left. At bars 94 and 96 may be seen the motif of a second and a fourth from *Daphnis*.

The harmonies of this passage, from bar 85:



1) Played by the flute in Ravel's orchestration.
2) Always on the double bassoon in the orchestral version.

In the rallentando, two bars before the original tempo resumes, the G♯ is waiting to resolve onto A, the third of the main key of F major.

3) **Recapitulation**, from bar 106.

The Beauty and Beast themes are combined, which changes the harmonies[1].

From bar 121 the theme of the Beast turns to contrary motion: it rises. A second development, at bar 128, imitates the first, taken from the commentary on the first theme, on a $\frac{9}{7}{}_{+}$ pedal with lowered third.

Beauty's theme undergoes elimination as previously before the recapitulation, until it has only two notes. Meanwhile, the theme of the Beast rises onto a diminished seventh chord at bar 140. The two themes exasperate one another, as if from the depths of despair.

The music stops abruptly, after a quick-tempo ***ff***, **Vif.**

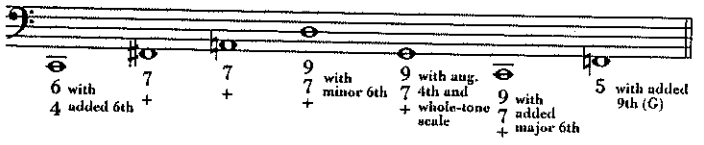
Pause, 𝄐

Awaiting, total silence, what will happen?

4) **Coda**

In a glissando, ***pp***, the Beast is transformed into the charming Prince. The theme of the Prince is the same as that of the Beast, but in a very high register[2]. Poetry of the F major $\frac{6}{4}$ chord. Beauty does not sing: she marvels in contemplation of this beautiful Prince in front of her.

The harmonic scheme is simple:

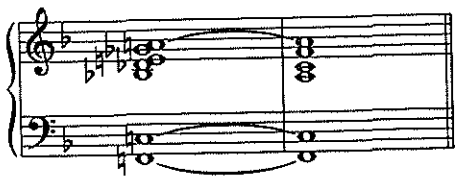


1) They are always played by, respectively, clarinet and double bassoon in Ravel's orchestration.
2) Played by solo violin in harmonics in the orchestral version.

Over this last, major chord the theme of the Prince sings out at a **Presque lent** tempo in the middle register while Beauty sings her theme in arpeggiated octaves in the high register – and the tonic pedal remains to the end of the movement.

The rise of the four bars before the final chord is constructed on this harmony: a tonic eleventh chord with added sixth (A), altered fifth (G♭ or F♯) and minor ninth (D♭).

Here is the chord and its resolution:



5. Le Jardin féérique (The Fairy Garden)

It is the garden of childhood and the human heart. All the fairyness of childhood is in this music, which is like finding an old toy that brings tears to one's eyes, like the past which might break if one touched it.

It is a piece in C major, restrained in feeling all through, for, despite the final ***ff*** where C major bursts forth and the garden opens, one cannot make out the secret hidden inside.

It is a huge feat musically and a signature piece for Ravel, whose lyricism and sense of feeling always kept about them something noble and mysterious.

The movement can be analysed thus:

1) Period A
2) Rise B for the first time, crescendo then diminuendo
3) High theme, with different harmonizations forming the background

4) Diatonic rise, decrescendo
5) Recapitulation in C replacing period A
6) Rise B twice, on the fourth degree, crescendo, reaching towards a perfect chord of C major, ***pp***.

The tempo **Lent et grave** for a finale somewhat recalls the ends of works by Schumann... *Der Dichter spricht* from *Kinderszenen*, the last piece of the *Davidsbündlertänze*, of the *Humoreske*, etc. May one also think of this passage from St Matthew's Gospel? :

> 'Unless you become as little children, you will not enter the Kingdom of Heaven'
> (xviii.14)

1) Period A starts in the middle register. At bar 5 appear again falling and rising seconds as in the first movement, harmonized by a $\frac{9}{7}$ chord on A with lowered third.

At bar 9 one might think of the start of *Une Barque sur l'océan* (A Galleon at Sea), from Ravel's collection *Miroirs* (Mirrors):



2) The first rise B (bar 14)



is also the motif of the *Pavane*, and this motif is played three times, leading into the Phrygian mode on E.

3) The middle section (bar 23) conveys the theme that starts in E Dorian and later is harmonized in C♯ Dorian (third degree of A major). The progressions recall Fauré.

Bar 29: E Mixolydian. Bar 31: G♯ Dorian. Bar 33: again the same notes of the theme. Harmonization in the Mixolydian mode. Everything here is arpeggiated, spread out, giving a feeling of unreality.

4) Bar 36: a diatonic rise through a decrescendo from ***f*** to ***pp*** gives a sense of withdrawal, maintained by chords (all arpeggiated) that open fanwise, from the middle register to the treble and bass extremes.

5) The recapitulation, with no more arpeggios, is in C – 'white chords' and calm rhythmic values. It is only a tonal recapitulation, without the theme, replacing what was period A.

6) The second rise B (bar 44) is made on the fourth degree in C, on an F-C pedal, in a hyper-major progression, with two bells (C-G) and at a molto crescendo whose outcome is the perfect C major chord at bar 50.

The garden opens in a quasi-orchestral flood, with glissandos, bells, and everything comes to a stop... The feeling stays fixed by this chord, as if it were a marble statue.

The garden has only been glimpsed. The great gate stays closed; the garden, interior and fairylike, cannot be trespassed upon, for it is the secret of each human being. It is what each must dream of...

* *
*

GASPARD DE LA NUIT

(Gaspard of the Night)

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GASPARD DE LA NUIT

(Gaspard of the Night)
by Maurice Ravel

Three poems for piano after Aloysius Bertrand

Analysis by Olivier Messiaen
after his piano score

About Aloysius Bertrand and the literary work

Louis (or Aloysius) Bertrand was a French writer who was born in 1807 and died in 1841.

Gaspard de la Nuit is a devilish character, an amusing and poetic incarnation of Satan, who Bertrand claimed gave him a book of poems. These poems (which of course Bertrand wrote himself) are entitled 'Fantasies in the manner of Rembrandt and Callot'.

Rembrandt, the Dutch painter (1606-1669), was the creator of chiaroscuro (*The Night Watch*, etc.), of mystery and meditation, the nature and the divine – the poetry of silence.

Jacques Callot was a French engraver (1592-1635) known for his tavern scenes, images of rough life – the poetry of noise.

Gaspard de la Nuit contains poems on the Flemish school, old Paris, medieval chronicles, Spain and Italy, *La Nuit et ses prestiges* (The Night and its Glories), etc.

Ondine comes from *La Nuit et ses prestiges* – *Le Gibet* and *Scarbo* are the last pieces in the collection.

I thought I heard
A vague harmony enchanting my sleep,
And near me emerging a murmur like
The broken song of a voice sad and tender.
(Charles Brugnot: *The Two Geniuses*)

Ondine (Water Nymph)

'Listen! Listen! This is me, this is Ondine, skimming with these water drops the resonant lozenges of your window, lit by the dull rays of the moon; and here, in a dress of moire, is the lady of the castle, on her balcony contemplating the beautiful starry night and the lovely lake asleep.

'Each wave is an ondine swimming in the current; each current is a path snaking towards my palace; and my palace is of fluid build, at the bottom of the lake, in the triangle of fire, earth and air.

'Listen! Listen! My father strikes the croaking water with a branch of green alder, and my sisters caress with their spume arms the cool isles of grasses, water lilies and gladioli, or else they laugh at the decaying, bearded willow with his fishing rod.'

Having murmured her song, she begged me take her ring on my finger, to become the husband of an Ondine and go with her to her palace, to become king of the lakes.

And when I replied that I loved a mortal, she, sulky and piqued, let fall some tears, burst out laughing and vanished in showers that streamed white the length of my blue panes.

Aloysius Bertrand

Note in the second paragraph of the poem how the four elements – water (in the waves and the lake), fire, earth and air – are joined in the same breath. This happens often in the work of Omar Khayyām, the twelfth-century Persian poet and mathematician.

Ondins (male) and ondines (female) are spirits inhabiting waters (in Germanic and Scandinavian mythology).

1. Ondine[1]

Summary of the form, sonata form of slow tempo:

1) Exposition of the first and second themes (melodic and slow).
2) Central development including a third theme, melodic and slow, modulating.
3) Reprise of the first theme and Coda.

1) The **opening** refers to the beginning of the poem:
'Listen! Listen! This is me, this is Ondine, skimming with these water drops the resonant lozenges of your window, lit by the dull rays of the moon...'

The scene is set by the right hand alone, on a chord of the major ninth with added minor sixth.



in a combination of trill and repeated notes.

The rhythm is an interversion: 

1) The bar numbering in this analysis includes the incomplete first bar of the piece



The first theme (slow) enters in the left hand in bar 3, its first period extending through six bars:



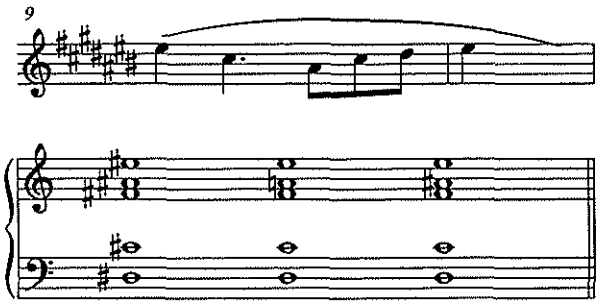
This first theme is in C♯ major on the mode:



Note in bars 4-5 this melodic turn:



The second period, beginning at bar 9, is a first commentary of six bars, on the first theme but on another degree:



Ninth chord with minor third

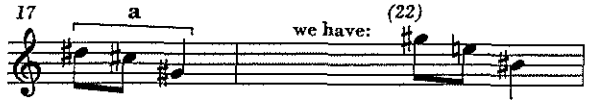


In the following bar (11) the song, still played by the left hand, is above the right hand. So as not to get in its way, the F♯ is suppressed in the right hand through the second beat, and then the A♮ is suppressed through the third beat.

At bar 15 the first period of the first theme returns, but in octaves and arpeggiated. The initial accompaniment formula encompasses middle and high registers in a garland surrounding the theme, whereas before the range had not exceeded an octave. The whole gives an impression of fluidity, accentuated by the theme's harp-like arpeggiation.

The third period (bar 17) is the second commentary developing the melodic motif **a** : D♯ C♯ G♯ that was noted in bar 5 – but here (in the right hand) it is descending. The following bar, in $\frac{2}{4}$ is a whole-tone chord with a foreign note: the D♯ which is an appoggiatura to B♯. These two bars are played twice and the interval is enlarged.

Instead of:



and then a further enlarging:



the octave descending in three jumps (two intervals of a second).

The left hand is written in harp style, a ***ppp*** scale of G♯ major from the bass to the middle-high register.

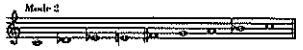
The following bar (24) shows a new kind of accompaniment, with the formula shared between the hands.

The chord is a ninth, with tonic instead of leading note. But at the third beat the D♯ pedal gives this analysis: +4 with added sixth, twice, on the two last quavers. In this I personally see my second mode[1], and with the appoggiaturas we have the 'chords of reversions transposed on the same bass note'[2].



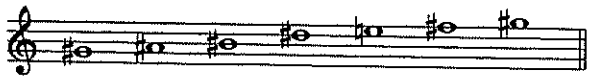
A seventh in three leaps (once more our fragment **a**) appears at bar 27, and another at bar 29. A ritenuto restores the background formula at bar 31, by a descending fourth, G♯ D♯ between bars 30 and 31. The melody comes to rest in G♯ major. And we find the same demisemiquavers in combination with trills and repeated chords for the entry of the second theme at bar 33:



1)  See explanation about the "modes of limited transpositions" in Olivier Messiaen, *Traité de rythme, de couleur et d'ornithologie*, Tome VII, Paris, 2002, Alphonse Leduc.

2) See Olivier Messiaen, *Traité de rythme, de couleur et d'ornithologie*, Tome VII, Paris, 2002, Alphonse Leduc, pp. 135-140.

This second theme is in the dominant, in G♯ major on the mode:



which is a major ninth with added minor sixth:



Period 1, with the attractive turn (**a**) of fifth and fourth descending: A♯ G♯ D♯. Period 1: antecedent.

The fragment: 

in bars 34-35 is taken from the second period of the first theme (see bar 12).

Period 1 is repeated, but this is its consequent, at bar 38, and sung in octaves – and no longer in simple notes.

At bar 40 the rising and descending arpeggio is a new ninth chord:



End of the second theme's consequent, on the tonic chord of D♯ major in bar 42 (the dominant of G♯ major, the key of the second theme's exposition, from bar 33).

2) Central developement

This modulates and comprises five sections.

Section I

Alternation between the first theme and the third, which enters at bar 46 in the bass. This brief third theme is built on this melodic figure:



and on two dominant seventh chords: on C and on G♭ on the fourth beat.

Bar 47 rises in quavers in the left hand towards the first theme presented in the treble, by the right hand. The background theme follows this ascent. The first theme, at bar 48, is played by the left hand in octaves, while the right hand continues the background theme in the treble in demisemiquavers.

C remains the implied bass, giving a sonority of seventh and ninth to this first theme.

In the third beat of bar 50 the right hand forms a double appoggiatura of this ninth chord, with F♯ and C♯.

The third theme, over an A pedal, is presented at bar 51, still in the bass; then it rises (as before) in quavers towards the second theme.

Section II

This begins at bar 53. The second theme is sung within a combination of arpeggios and broken octaves. Above: here is the influence of the violin (open strings and harmonics). Below: arpeggios on various chords and on the dominant pedal A (see *Laideronnette, impératrice des pagodes* in *Ma Mère l'Oye*). The melodic motif of the second theme is shared

between the hands, and its descending fifth and fourth, so attractive, are surrounded by garlands.

An arpeggio-rocket lifts off, crescendo, in bar 54 to redeliver this second theme in octaves in the treble. Theme cut, ending on a perfect chord of G major.

Section III

This is a long ascent on the third theme, illustrating in particular the second paragraph of the poem:

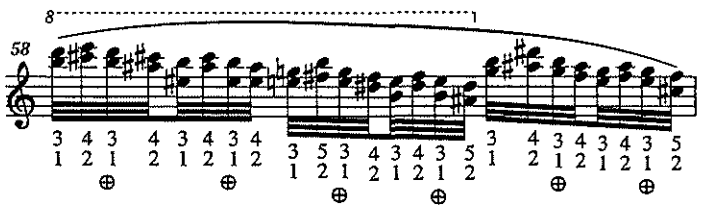
> 'Each wave is an ondine swimming in the current; each current is a path snaking towards my palace; and my palace is of fluid build, at the bottom of the lake, in the triangle of fire, earth and air.'

The third theme is in the bass in octaves (one senses quartet writing and the orchestra's trombones from bar 58). This is, with the ensuing fourth section, the most virtuoso part of the piece.

In the right hand a typically pianistic gesture: a gesture in double notes recalling Chopin's study in thirds.

In the bass, a long swaying on the diminished fifth: C♯ G♮ : (two dominant sevenths, linked by $\frac{7}{5}$).

The gesture:



descends in groups of four attacks, which suggests a rotation of the right thumb. The pianist might also think of turning the hand, over the thumb on the double notes marked with a cross. To sustain the fifth and sixth notes of the theme in the bass, the

right hand doubles them with a rising arpeggio, telling out the notes of the dominant seventh on G.

Some notes of the gesture in double notes are foreign and serve the gesture's symmetry:

in the first beat the A♯ (added sixth)

in the second beat the D♯ (ninth), then the A♯ (appoggiatura to the diminished fifth).

(One might point out a relationship between the second theme's A♯ G♯ D♯ – and the third theme's E D G♯ in bars 58-59 and 59-60.) Bars 58 and 59 are identical. Bar 60 sees the third theme rising in equal quavers ($\frac{7}{+}$ and $\frac{7}{3}$ chords on C♯) to modulate into another lighting: B♭ and E♮ in the extreme bass (still supporting the third theme). The gesture in double notes takes on a different figuration: descending thirds and fourths and the chromatic scale. The symmetry of the upper part in this gesture can be understood as that of passing notes: these are 'passing groups', as in Chopin's *Berceuse*.



The configuration of the pianistic gesture is altered: the gesture has to be faster (it goes in groups of two notes and has lost its curve). In the following bar (62) the theme rises in quavers (as in bar 60) to reach a perfect G♯ major chord: this 'rocket group' descends, decrescendo, in order to take up a long rise in equal quavers from the bass to the treble, proceeding scalewise through three bars.

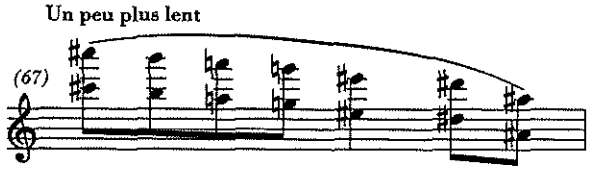
A chord for each of these bars:



The crescendo has to be enormous, and the rallentando somewhat suggests the power of an organ pulling out all the stops.

Section IV

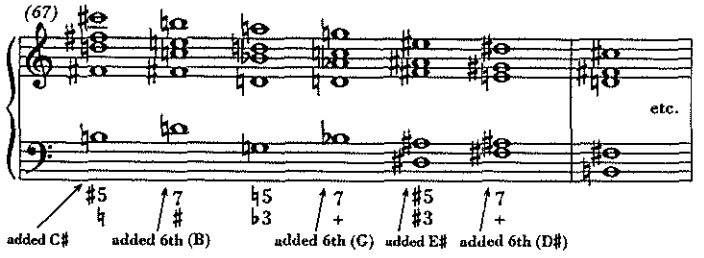
This is a great descent on the second theme:



Piano writing covering all the registers.

Arpeggios in both hands with, in the right, change of position by the fingering 1-5, and in the left hand by 5-1.

This bar 67 is repeated, but an octave lower. Here are the chords (it is a march):



(The upper part gives a whole-tone scale in melodic form.)

The third and fourth beats of bar 67 bring the end of the second theme with change of degree: at its exposition (bar 33),

there was a return to the A♯, here the melody continues to fall (still with the descending fourth on the last two quavers of the bar).

This section goes from ***ff*** to ***p*** as quiet as possible' for the white-note glissando introducing the fifth section.

At bar 69: 

we have the

end of the second theme (see bar 34), a motif which is heard three times: in the middle register, in the treble, then with each note laid out in three octaves. This last appearance is similar to the fourth system on the fourth page (bar 38) in terms of the demisemiquaver background.

The chord : 
of the seventh and

diminished fifth seems to be waiting for another lighting, its wait protracted by a ritardando.

Section V

A very poetic surprise. Two lightings at once, by means of two glissandos: the first cold and calm on the white notes, the second warm and slower on the black.

C major, then the pentatony F♯-G♯-A♯-C♯-D♯ leading to F♯ major.

Bar 73: the first motif:



is an expansion of the fragment **a** taken from the second commentary on the first theme (see bar 23, where it was already

accompanied by a rising scale of G♯ major). Here the octave in three leaps (two seconds) is accompanied by the glissando, evocative of harp writing - a glissando followed by a descending arpeggio of C-E-G-A with two little waves that rise and fall: ⌒

Now comes the second lighting: warm light, the motif of an octave in three leaps is surrounded by a pentatonic efflorescence from the bass to the treble, F♯ G♯ A♯ C♯ D♯. When the treble is reached, on D♯, the tonic of F♯major affirms a bass on which a harmonic litany will be grafted: D♮, F♮, D♯ (third degree already heard in bar 24).

This melodic motif recalls Debussy's *Prélude à 'L'Après-midi d'un faune'* (Prelude to 'The Afternoon of a Faun'). The interlaced hands suggest Debussy's prelude *Cloches à travers les feuilles* (Bells across the Leaves) - and also Chopin's Etude in A♭ Op.25 No.1 for the placing of melodic notes in the middle of arpeggios. Six notes against four: rising and descending arpeggios with the fall through a fourth, that formula beloved of Ravel, found in the first movement of *Ma Mère l'Oye*.

In the right hand a rising fourth:



In the left hand a descending fourth:



(see also the *Prelude* of *Le Tombeau de Couperin*).

While at bar 24, on a D♯ pedal, we had two tritones (augmented fourths on G and B♭ (both with added sixths),

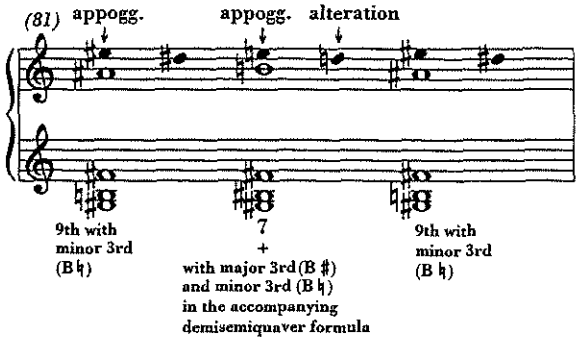
at bar 77 there are two dominant chords, second inversion, +6 on A and +6 on C.

In bar 79 the chord extends fanwise, the melody rises as the bass descends, still on the perfect chord of F♯ major.

A 'rocket group', parallel in the two hands, introduces a dominant ninth (see bar 28) before the reprise of the first theme in the following bar.

3) Reprise of the first theme: the first period arrives at bar 81. The background theme returns, with the formula of changing registers (as at bar 15). This reprise takes place on the dominant of C♯ major.

The chords are as follows:



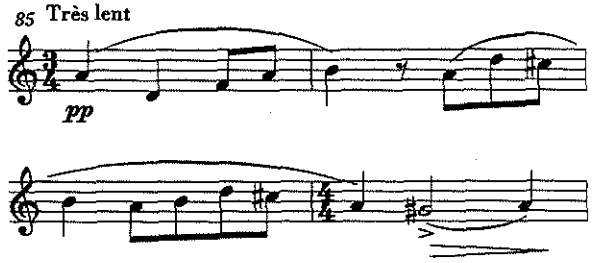
Two bars later a marvellous melodic turn brings this first period of the first theme to a close:



leading to a strange chord of D minor – strange because it stops the background (like a theatre curtain that rises on an agonizing silence).

And here is the murmured dialogue, ***pp***, in a **Très lent** (very slow) tempo:

'And when I replied that I loved a mortal, she, sulky and piqued, let fall some tears, ...'



Period 2 of the first theme is taken from the first commentary on that theme (see bars 11-14).

Coda

'... burst out laughing and vanished in showers that streamed white the length of my blue panes.'

After the silence of the dialogue here is the burst of laughter, marked **Rapide et brillant**, in a crescendo towards a ***ff*** in the treble.

Double arpeggio, of C major on E♭ $\flat 9$ $\flat 7$ +, resulting in a minor ninth with added major sixth (the opposite of the opening chord on the first page).

A great spray of water, with the hands in parallel, from the bass to the treble, then going backwards and forwards towards the middle register, followed by two waves back and forth in the treble. The 'streaming' is formed by fourteen little descents of four demisemiquavers each on diminished sevenths whose melody is created from two seconds: C-B♭ and G-F, which are notes added to the chords but belonging to the pentatonic scale. Having reached the low register and come to rest on a D♯ bass,

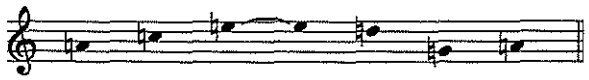
the arpeggio and the melodic turn, shared between the hands, again recall harp writing.

The semiquavers oscillate between a descending second and an ascending one. There again we have a motif from the pentatonic scale: G♯ F♯ C♯ D♯. One cannot but marvel at these curves so typical of Ravel:

Ondine :



and *Ma Mère l'Oye* : *Pavane de la Belle au bois dormant*



and *Laideronnette, impératrice des pagodes :*



and many more...

The tempo relaxes, the semiquaver seconds become quavers, and a low C♯ establishes itself in the bass, for the ending in C♯ major. This is, at bar 90, the perfect major chord with added minor sixth from bar 1, the sonority from the start of the piece evoking the sad smile of Leonardo da Vinci's St John the Baptist.

« *Bien égal de sonorité* » (Fully even in sound) – **Sans ralentir** (Without slowing down) – these indications well express that there is no question of human feeling here but of a legend in which water is the principal character, with its mysterious inhabitants, its colours both cold and warm, its fluidity, its poetry, its virtuosity, its melodic curves suggesting the abrupt forward-backward movements of the aquatic world.

The final chord is written in a very refined way: after four waves back and forth the arpeggio rises again and, substituting for the pedal, the left hand reclaims the notes it held before. The movement is as if suddenly frozen, petrified. Time is stopped...

...what do I see shifting around these gallows?
(Goethe's *Faust*)

Le Gibet (The Gallows)

Ah! This that I hear, is it the night's north wind yelping or the hanged man who pushes out a sigh on the sinister-looking fork?

Would it be some cricket singing crouched in the moss and barren ivy that the woodland, pitying, uses for shoes?

Would it be some fly on the hunt sounding its horn to ears that cannot hear the fanfare of hallali?

Would it be some beetle in full flight picking a bloody hair from his bald skull?

Or would it even be some spider embroidering half a yard of muslin to make a tie for this strangled neck?

It is the bell ringing against the walls of a town, below the horizon, and the carcass of a hanged man reddened by the setting sun.

Aloysius Bertrand

Fork : Y shaped structure of wooden beams on which the condemned were hanged.

Gallows : Several such forks.

Hallali : Horn call announcing the stag at bay.

Beetle : The original word *escarbot* (from the Latin *scarabeus*, a scarab) is a slang term for various beetles, including the stag-beetle.

Yard : Bertrand has *aune*, an ancient measure equivalent to 1,188 metres.

A rhythmic pedal on the note B♭ travels right through the piece and evokes at once: 'the bell ringing against the walls

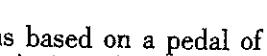
of a town', the unbearably repeated buzzing of the 'fly on the hunt sounding its horn to ears that cannot hear' (i.e. those of the hanged man) and death going inexorably about its work with the patience of the 'spider embroidering' its cloth. Apart from this Ravel employs three little motifs, all very short:

Motif 1 : 'the setting sun': night and death that fall on all things.

Motif 2 : 'the night's north wind yelping' and 'the hanged man who pushes out a sigh on the sinister-looking fork': an expressive motif necessitating a feminine rhythm of anacrusis-accent-mute.

Motif 3 : bunch of chords in a converging march: the spider's cloth spread over the hanged man's neck.

2. Le Gibet

The entire piece is based on a pedal of B♭ that is also a rhythmic pedal on: 
with some variations, such as might be produced by the striking of bells, suggesting 'the bell ringing against the walls of a town'.

Greek rhythms:



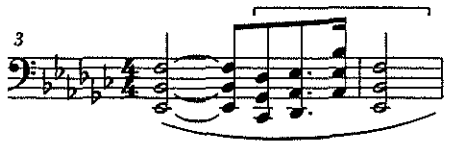
or iamb (⏑ –) and bacchius (⏑ – –)

or group of two values and this group executed twice, the second time with the second value extended by repetition.

The bell : 

One should note that the B♭ is in octaves, but not for the final repetition.

Motif 1 enters at bar 3. Its chords are constructed from two fifths on top of one another:



It is presented across the extent of three octaves.

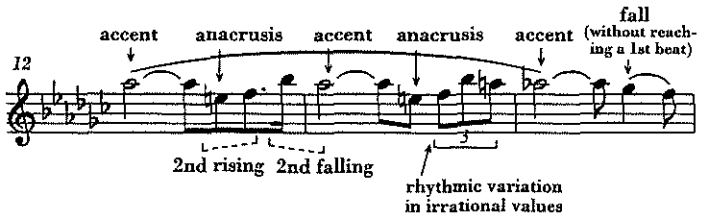
The melodic turn D♭-E♭-B♭-F recalls Debussy's *L'Après-midi d'un faune*, and the final fall through a fourth suggests the Russians.

Motif 2 (presented in octaves between the hands at bar 6) may be analysed thus:



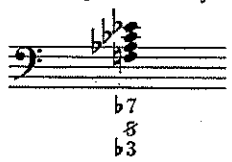
Next motif 1 returns, then motif 2 again at bar 10, but in thirds in both hands.

At bar 12 comes a new presentation of motif 1:



See the motif from the first bar of this presentation in Debussy's *Hommage à Rameau*, pp. 10-11.

The harmonic analysis is very rich:

Chord :  on a low B♭ pedal.

Triple appoggiatura: 



+4 with added minor sixth.





These two chords are the reversal of the harmonies of Golaud's theme in the first act of Debussy's *Pelléas*.

The last two chords of bar 14 come from the melodic minor scale and from the major ninth with added minor sixth, as in the first piece, *Ondine*.

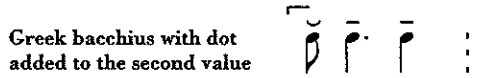
In this same bar the bell in the middle register has an extra value:



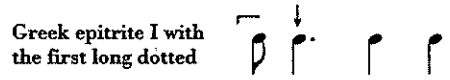
There follow two bars (15-16) with chords of a fourth over a fifth (reverse sonority to the two fifths of the beginning).

For this chord of fifth plus fourth see Debussy's prelude *Et la lune descend sur le temple qui fut* (And the moon is descending on the temple as was).

The rhythm of the bell in the middle register is modified thus:

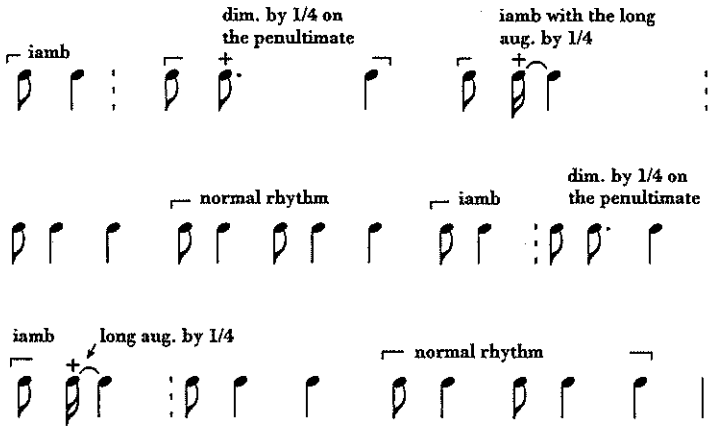


followed by the same thing but repeating the last value:



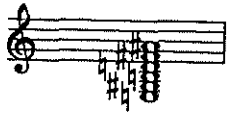
The normal rhythm returns on the fourth quaver of bar 17.

With it comes motif 1, over a low E♭, pedal, in a new transposed presentation. The bell makes interesting rhythmic variants in bars 19-25. Here they are, separated from the music (and from the barring):



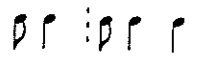
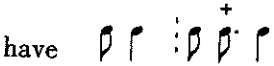
At bar 20 the first drapery closes fanwise. The harmonic motif A here comprises a bunch of chords in a converging march (see the second act of Paul Dukas's *Ariane*) over a ninth chord with added diminished fifth:

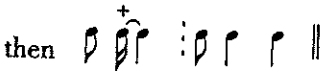
G♯ chord in the bass in first inversion (A♭)



This is the motif 3 indicated at the start of this analysis, the spider's cloth spread over the hanged man's neck.

What caused the rhythmic variants of the bell was the piano writing, with arpeggiation in both hands, since it is impossible to cover everything simultaneously, and therefore the player has to take values in the normal rhythmic pedal a semiquaver too early.

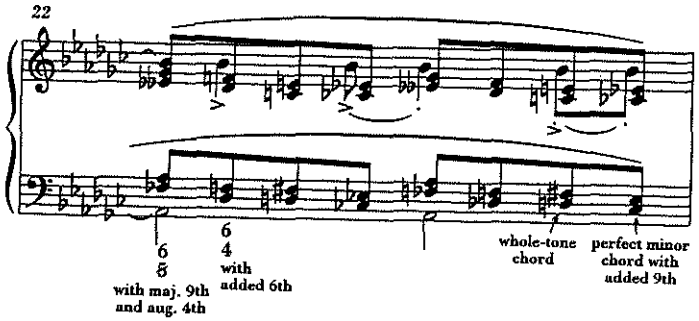
Instead of  we have 

too early, then 

What brings about a diminution by 1/4 of the penultimate note of the pedal (first term) is the augmentation by 1/4 of the long of the iamb (second term).

(There is a feeling of dread in this motif 3, '***ppp*** very legato', as if the spider were coiling up the fly without any reaction, the extreme registers converging towards the middle in order to cover it and annihilate it.)

Harmonic analysis of the third bar of this motif 3 **A** (bar 22):



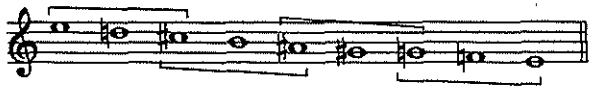
One thinks of the 'hair' scene in dans *Pelléas* :



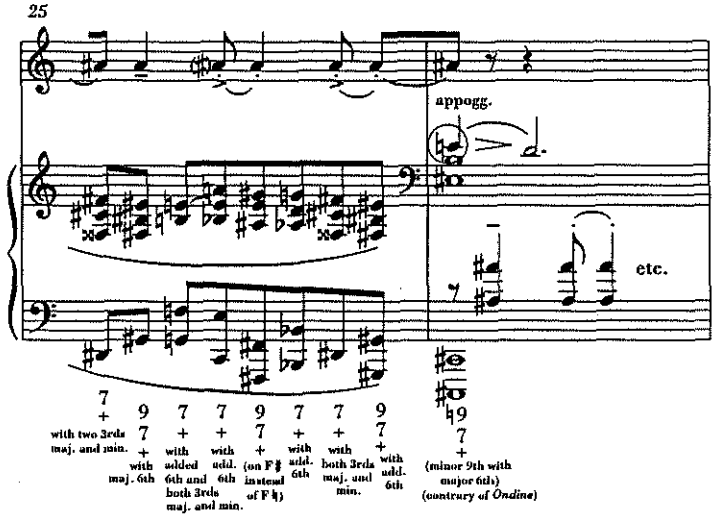
for the first two chords of bar 22.

The second 'bunch of chords' in converging march – motif 3 **B** (beginning at bar 23) – gives us the same music but other harmonies.

In the bass, G♮. The basis is the second 'mode of limited transpositions'[1]:



Analysis of the third bar of this motif 3 **B** (bar 25) – which is a march of $\frac{7}{+}$ – :



1) See note no 1 p. 28

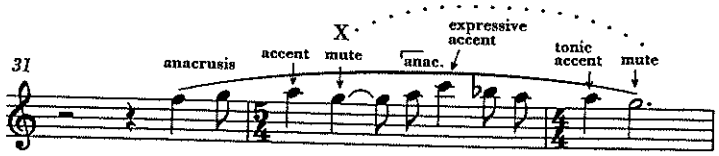
New lighting for motif 2 at bar 28, '***pp*** *un peu en dehors, mais sans expression*' (***pp*** a little in relief, but without expression).

The atmosphere is cold, icy, inhuman, accentuated by the regular iambic succession ⏑ – of B♭ bells.

The melody, of expressive character, has a feminine rhythm:



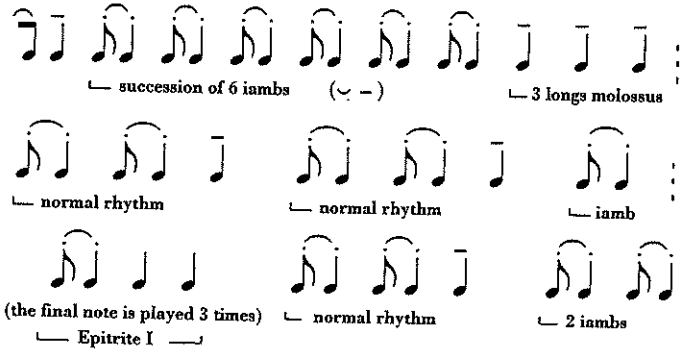
And further, at bar 31:

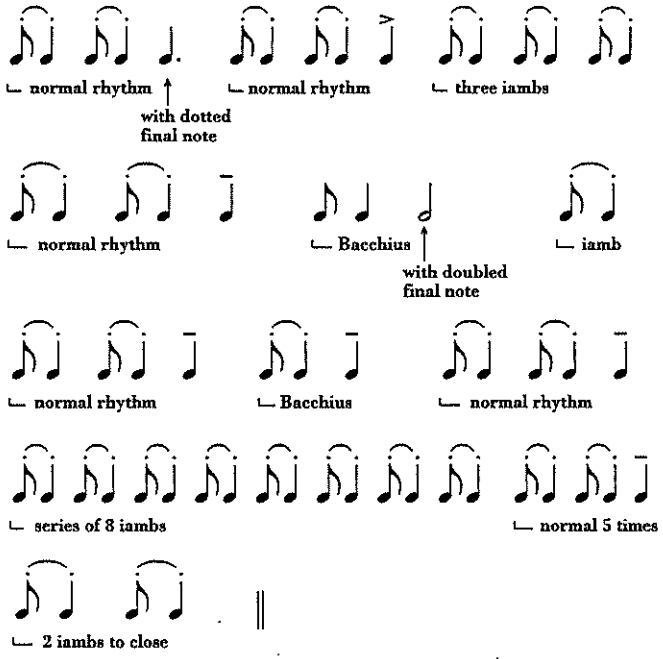


New rhythmic presentation and melodic extension by x····· (bars 28-34) three times.

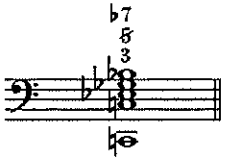


Here is the rhythm of the bell (B♭) from bar 28:





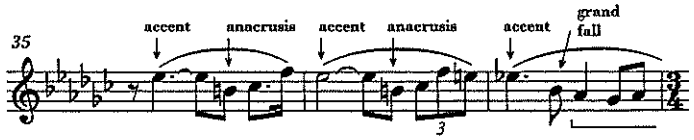
Harmonically, bar 35:



Through five bars there is a low C pedal.

Bar 38: minor ninth with diminished fifth on the first beat, ninth chord with the ninth in the bass on the second.

Motif 1 in its new presentation and still transposed (with some alterations) here achieves its longest phrase, from bar 35:

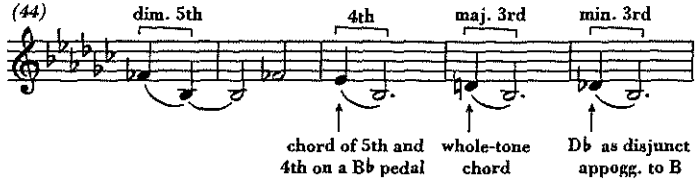




Motif 3 from bar 40 (converging march) with still other harmonies. The simultaneous presence of the B♭ pedal is effective; it is the leading note of the chord. Altogether that produces a mode of B (unused in plainsong). Note the $\frac{9}{7}_{+}$ chord on G♭ with E♭, the added sixth.

This motif 3 is followed in the middle register by motif 2 from after the third beat of bar 41 – anacrusis, accent on the first beat of bar 43, then its mute – for a final appearance in bar 43, in a brief fragment. The fan is closed.

A narrowing of intervals in the inner voice darkens the passage further; everything withdraws into blackness:



On this minor third motif 1 enters in the bass (chords of two superposed fifths, as in bar 3).

There remains only the extremely low B♭ and the B♭ bell in the middle register, whose ringings calm down, blurring the landscape in the gloom of night.

Silence, total engulfment.

The resonance has disappeared...

He looked under his bed, in the fireplace, in the chest: no-one. He could not understand how he had got in, how he had escaped.

Hoffmann : *Tales*

Scarbo

Oh! How often I have heard and seen him, Scarbo, when the moon shines in the sky at midnight like a silver shield on a sky-blue banner sown with golden bees!

How often I have heard the buzz of his laughter in the shadow of my alcove, and the scrape of his nails on the silk of my bed curtains!

How often I have seen him come down from the floor, pirouette on one foot and roll through the room like a spindle fallen from a witch's distaff!

Did I think he then vanished? The dwarf would grow and grow, from me to the moon, like the belltower of a Gothic cathedral, a little gold bell swinging on his pointed hat!

But soon his body would go blue, diaphanous as the wax of a candle, his face would pale like the wax of a taper – and suddenly he had gone out.

Aloysius Bertrand

Some quotations from Aloysius Bertrand on the subject of Scarbo:

'the gnome who gets drunk on the oil of my lamp!'

'But Scarbo is the one who cuts my throat, and who, to cauterize my bleeding wound, plunges his finger of red-hot iron into the furnace!' – *La Chambre gothique* (The Gothic Room)

'Scarbo, gnome whose treasures abound...'

'– And Scarbo was in my cellar obliviously minting ducats and florins in time with the pendulum.' – *Le Fou* (The Fool)

'Where is your soul, for me to sit astride!... And my soul slid out in terror...

'But the dwarf, stayed in his neighing flight, rolled around like a spindle in the threads of his white mane.' – *Le Nain* (The Dwarf)

Ernst Theodor Amadeus Hoffmann: German writer, musician and draughtsman (1776-1822), most famed for his fantastical tales (*The Increase*, *The Sandman*, *The Ghostly Bridegroom*, etc.)

One of the *Pièces détachées* (Leaves Torn Off) of *Gaspard de la Nuit*, *Scarbo* is the penultimate poem in Aloysius Bertrand's book.

The character appears in several of the book's other poems (see *La Nuit et ses prestiges* : *La Chambre gothique* - *Scarbo* (the other poem with the same title) – *Le Fou* and *Le Nain*.

Scarbo is a gnome, a kind of creature who is a deformed and supernatural dwarf, and who, according to Jewish cabbalists,

lives in the bowels of the earth, guarding treasure. (The cabbala is a mysterious interpretation of the Bible, attributing a symbolic meaning to letters of the alphabet and numbers.)

PARACELSUS : Swiss alchemist and physician (1493-1541), inventor of the word 'gnome'.

Little explanations of the poem

Chest : Wooden box, used in the middle ages to store clothes. Wardrobe.

Silver shield on a sky-blue banner sown with golden bees : The moon, sky, stars: terms borrowed from heraldry, or the repertory of signs or armorial bearings that compose a shield.

Alcove : Niche made in a room as a place for one or more beds.

Come down from the floor : Is this a French-style floor, providing the wooden ceiling for the imagined room? Or does he arrive with his feet in the air, his head following?

Spindle : Small wooden instrument, bulging in the middle, for spinning on a distaff.

Distaff : Small stick, covered towards the top in hemp, flax, silk, etc, to be spun.

Diaphanous : Transmitting light but not transparent.

3. Scarbo

This masterpiece of music, this brilliant peak of the piano literature, comprises no fewer than eleven sections, boasting four themes:

A – B – C – D (D being the main theme).

We will analyse them in detail, section by section.

Section 1 : It is midnight

Theme A initiates the introduction: the first three notes of this theme appear in the extreme bass, mysterious, as if drawn from nothingness one after another, dragged, slid, still unformed – dominant of G♯ minor. A quaver rest cuts off these three ***pp*** notes before a timpani roll, *'très fondu, en trémolo'* (very much molten, tremolando), on a tritone chord with a pedal of the dominant in the middle register (see Spanish music, especially Albéniz's twelve piano pieces *Iberia*).

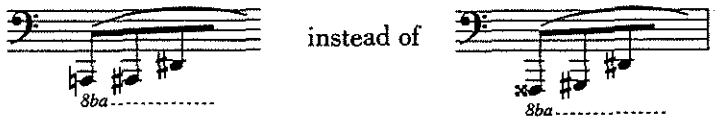
A vibration, a trembling, a terror of five seconds, the time of a very long pause.

The effect is reproduced a second time, with the chord an octave lower.

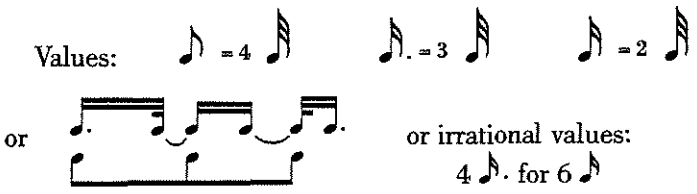
New halt.

The three notes begin again, being born from the depths, hesitant.

Ravel did not know modern pianos, with a bass extension, and had to write:



These quavers mysteriously begin a rise from the extreme bass to the extreme treble, starting slowly and ***pp*** to develop a crescendo and an accelerando created at once by note values and tempo.

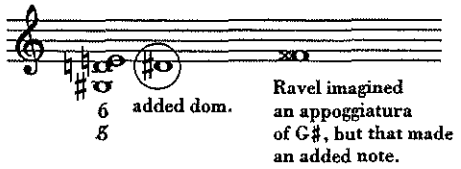


This is the apparition of Scarbo!

Ravel counted on the auditory confusion produced by the extreme bass to make it so that the accelerating gesture towards the extreme treble becomes resonant and brilliant. But once arrived at the super-high chord, trilled, we have, instead of a ***ff***, a sudden ***pp*** *subito*: a sort of sudden hole, rapidly made good by a crescendo from ***pp*** to ***ff*** at a fast tempo.

Effect: trilled chord of a string quartet with cymbal trill. (On the piano a trilled chord is easier and more effective when the hands cross, as here, the two hands pressing down one after the other.)

This whole rise, from bar 15, is based on the following chord:

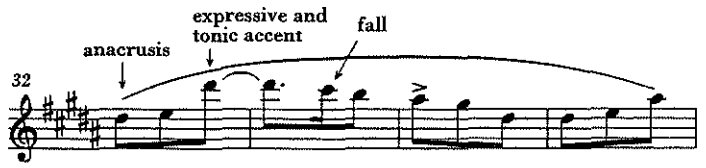


The crescendo-diminuendo on this trill is followed by a short silence.

Section 2

This begins at bar 32, and comprises the presentation of the three themes we will call A, B and C.

Theme A:



Derived from the three notes of the introduction, F×, G♯ and D♯, the first three notes of A expand these intervals.

Bar 37: two long values follow, each of them attacked after the first beat. The first is of 12 ♪, the second of 9 ♪, the two of

them making the motif of a descending fourth on a $^{9}_{7}$ chord with added sixth. A percussive effect, of pulsation on the two notes C♯ and G♯, through six bars, serves as a transition between themes A and B.

B enters at bar 52. This theme is presented in two parts, the first in staccato ♪ suggesting the timbre of a muted trumpet:



The rest of B, its second part, is in quavers and in descending fourths:



The chord in the first bar is $^{6}_{5}$ on B: sonority of the whole-tone scale with the foreign note A♯ – The chord of the second bar is +6 on B with the added sixth, C♯.

This theme B is repeated twice, and is followed by five bars of insistent major thirds – C♯ – E♯ and D – F♯ – over a trill of B and A♯ in the left hand ($^{\sharp 7}_{5}$ on G♯), a passage that could readily be orchestrated for two clarinets, oboe and cor anglais.

A silence of 9 ♪ (three bars) cuts off the discourse before the return of theme B at bar 73.

For this new presentation the writing is ampler: an arpeggio in the left hand rises and falls through three octaves, and the second part of theme B is played in broken octaves and semi-quavers.

From bar 80 we have a gesture as of muted violins in the right hand, the harmonies (+6 on B and $^{6}_{5}$ on B) being played pizzicato-fashion by the left hand, stepping over with the right.

The second 'mode of limited transpositions' accompanies the violin-style music in bars 86-92, stopping on a $^{\sharp 7}_{5}$ chord on E♯. The transition is made in the following bar (93) by an arpeggio with appoggiaturas, distributed between the hands on:

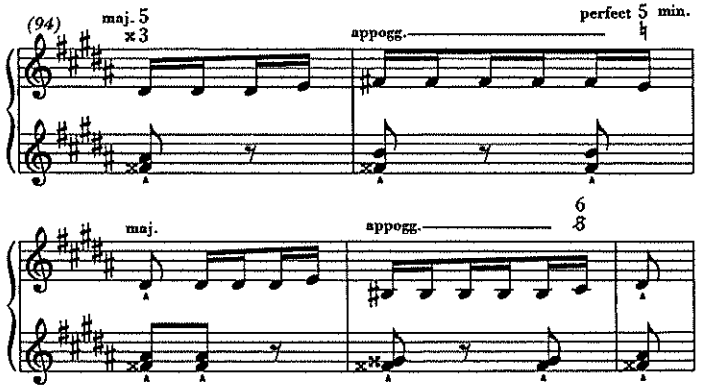


(F𝄪 and C𝄪 are appoggiaturas)

This arpeggio brings on theme C, its first appearance. The characteristic of this theme C is that it seems to belong to Spanish music (influence of the guitar). It has the hands crossing, the right below for the difficult repeated notes. This is where the following passage of the poem is illustrated:

> 'How often I have heard the buzz of his laughter in the shadow of my alcove, and the scrape of his nails on the silk of my bed curtains!'

This theme C thus enters at bar 94 on a perfect D♯ major chord.



1) See page 28 note no 1

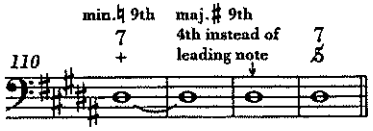
Continuing in ♪, the repeated notes are then replaced by octaves. The piano writing becomes richer, rises into the treble and reaches a texture having a counterpoint in ♪ distributed between the thumbs of the two hands:



Exasperation, crescendo, cut off by a bar of silence... Theme A splashes back at bar 110.

(The same structure as when it first appeared, at bar 32: anacrusis, expressive and tonic accent, fall.)

New harmonies, on a D♯ pedal:





In the right hand the G♯ honours the theme's ascending fourth.

The arpeggio descends into the extreme bass towards D♯ in order to take off in a rapid flight into the extreme treble (right hand now ascending with fingering 1 5 1 5).

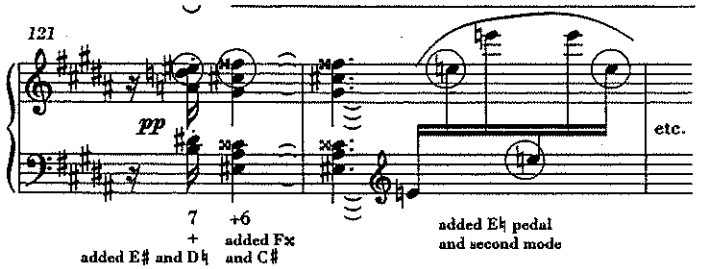
A bar of silence, the scene vanishes for only two seconds. Then comes the moon, and an atmosphere of supernatural terror:

> 'The moon untangled her hair with an ebony comb which silvered the hills, meadows and woods with a rain of glinting verses.'
>
> (Aloysius Bertrand – *Le Fou*)

Now comes the main theme: presentation and development of theme D and start of section 3. Midnight, atmosphere of terror!

Section 3

D is a iambic theme. At bar 121 the ⏑ – rhythm is represented by a short value one ♪ and a very long one 29 ♪ une ♪



Second 'mode of limited transpositions':



The entirety of the +6 chord with added notes and the added E♮ pedal gives the second 'mode of limited transpositions' (except for the B♮).

E♮ pedal: ♪ octaves in the right hand, ascending and descending, with ♪. octaves in the left hand, rising.

Alternate E♮s (circled in the example above) are struck by the thumbs of the two hands, giving repeated ♪ . The right hand makes a iambic rhythm of ♪♪ ♪♪

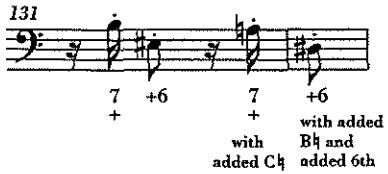
Everything is held together by the piano's pedal, at a dynamic level of ***pp*** or ***ppp*** for the E♮s « *très fondu et bien égal de sonorité* » (very molten and even in sonority).

At bar 131 the E♮ pedal stops, giving way to two iambs, two chords where the marvellous and strange are mingled.

Rhythm (bars 131-132):



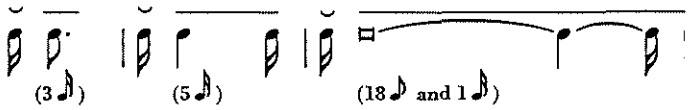
The harmonies:



with the added notes already indicated for the first two chords

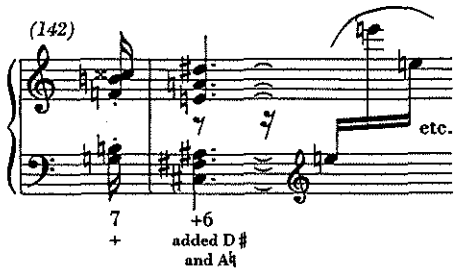
Then the first two chords of the main theme D reappear (see bar 121), the short value still being a ⌣ ( ) while the long value is of 23 and a (instead of 29 and a as it was the first time).

At bar 141 the iambs make these values:



The two descending chords are followed by a third plateau:

Bar 142:



Here the key of B major insinuates itself.

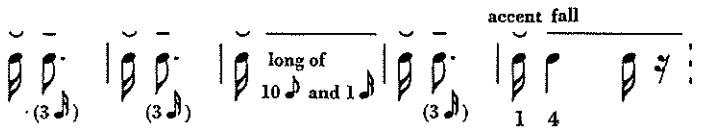
This is the second mode but in another transposition:



The E♮ pedal shortens itself further at bar 143 : a ⌣ ( ) and 18 and 1 (to make up the long).

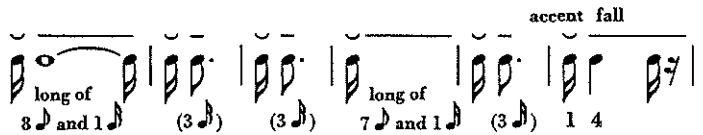
Since this section is extremely rich and complicated with its elastic iambs, we may try to characterize the rhythm of this main theme D according to three formulae. First, it has a iambic rhythm (⌣ –) (with a short value of 1 and a long decreasing from 29 and 1 | to 5 and 1 |. Secondly, it has a iambic rhythm where the long may be of 3 , 4 , 5 or 7 . And finally, it has a group of shorts and longs forming a feminine rhythm of anacrusis-accent-fall (or mute): see bars 172-173.

To continue our analysis of the iambs, which had got to bar 149:



Little break. Dominant pedal of D♭ major with A♭ shared between the hands, from the bass to the treble.

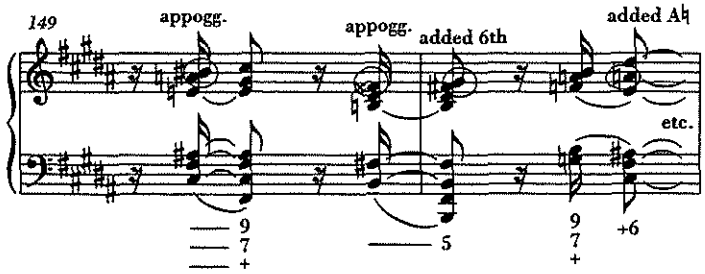
Bars 159-168:



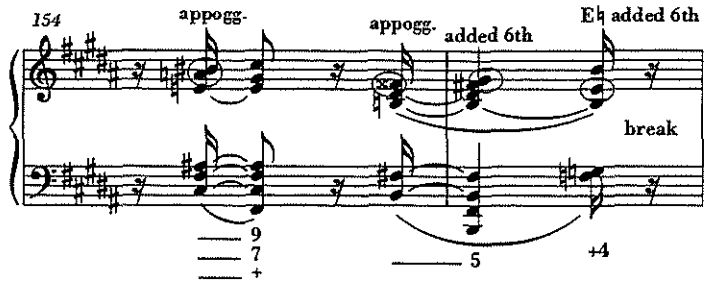
Little break.

As for the harmonies from bar 149:

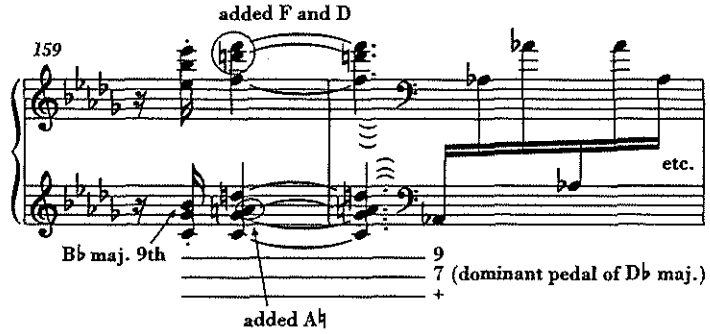
Bars 149-150:



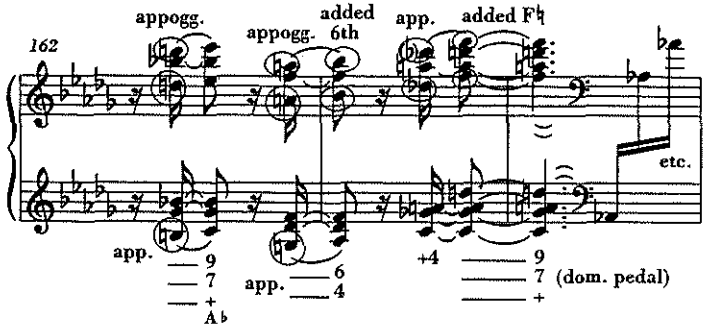
Bars 154-155:



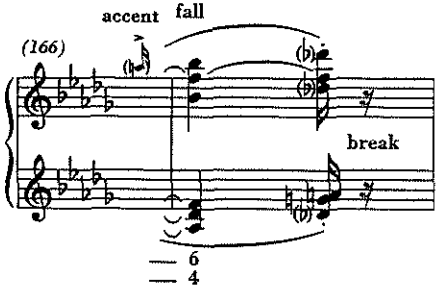
Bar 159:



Bars 162 and 163:

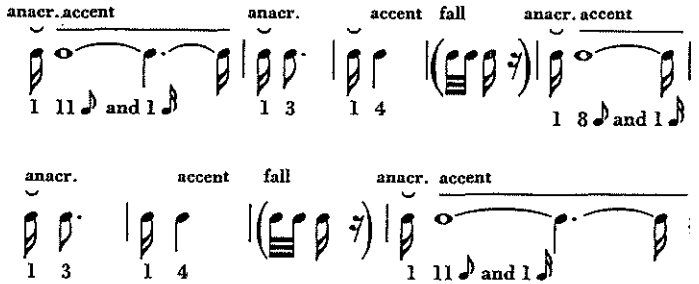


Bar 167:

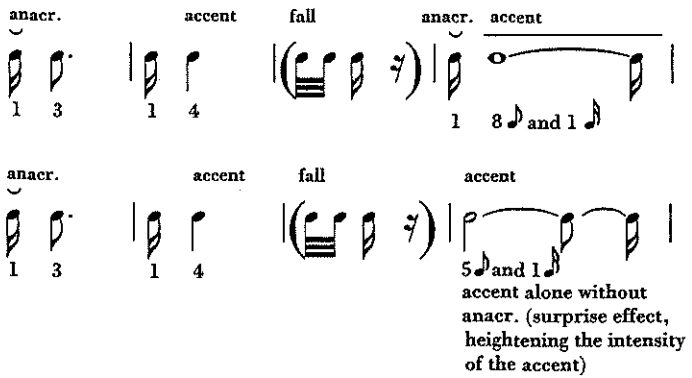


'...pirouette on one foot and roll through the room like a spindle fallen from a witch's distaff!'

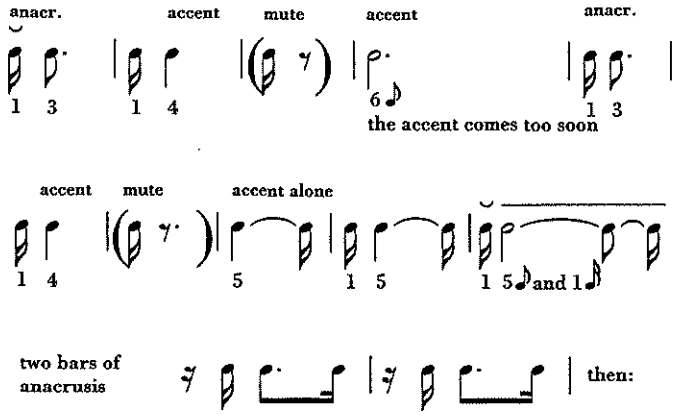
To continue the numbering of the iambs in bars 168-215:



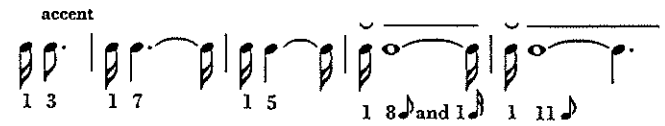
From bar 183:



From bar 192:



From bar 204:



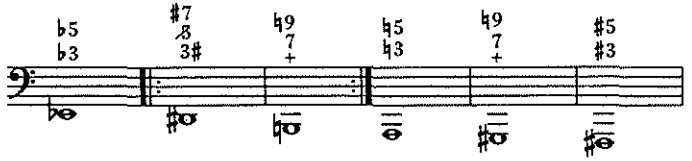
and so we arrive at section IV, beginning at bar 215.

Let us return to the harmonies whose discussion was left off at bar 167. We enter B♭ minor with the harmony of Golaud's theme from *Pelléas*: G♮ and E♮ on D♭-F-B♭ (perfect minor chord). The scheme is a perfect minor chord with disjunct appoggiaturas (increasingly disjunct for the upper voice), playing with the Indian mode:



Then the pedal makes everything resonate together: C, A♮, F, D♭, B♭, G♭, E♭. The perfect minor chord of B♭ has given way to that of E♭ in the bass.

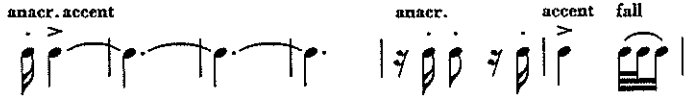
If we summarize this passage very briefly, from bar 179 onwards, we have:



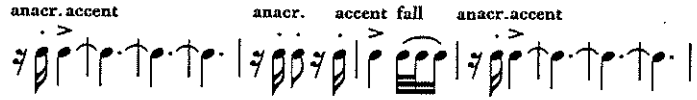
with, to be sure, many appoggiaturas and passing notes.

Let us come back to the phrasing from bar 168 onwards (where the main theme D appears) and separate it from the value counts:

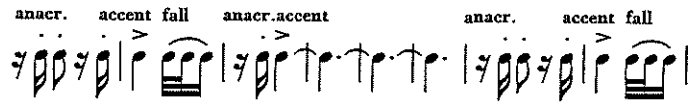
From bar 168:



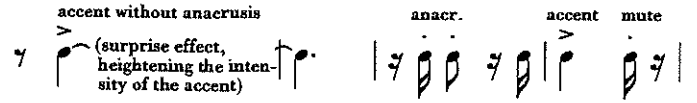
From bar 174:



From bar 183:



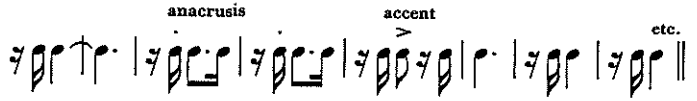
From bar 190:



From bar 194:



From bar 200:



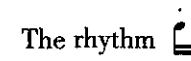
Note again that the main theme D reveals its definitive form at bar 168.

Pianistically this passage is difficult, being based in the left hand on the substitution of the fingers **5 1 3 1 3 1 5** from bar 168 onwards.

Ravel ends this extraordinary third section on a perfect chord of F♯ major, in the left hand in the extreme bass, while the right hand is in the extreme treble on the accent of bar 204. He then has the genius to create echoes of this accent descending through all the registers. There is a sensation of going down into the depths, and the more one drives into the blackness the more the long value is prolonged.

A nervous quaver in the bass serves as a springboard, from which the subject of discussion bounds back: it is theme B, which has not been heard for a long time (not since bar 73) and which has been chosen to personify section 4 (bars 215-255 inclusive).

Section 4 : (bar 215)

The rhythm  , cut off from its continuation by two bars, is announced for the first time, but here the accent is extended, the A♯ being held. The remaining six ♪ are presented normally, to complete this theme B.

But at bar 228 a new pianistic aspect appears (redoubtable even for pianists who practice it a hundred times a day!): arpeggio segments are alternated between the hands, descending from the extreme treble to the extreme bass to rise again in double arpeggios - with different numbers of notes in the two hands. While the right hand has nine ♪ in the first bar and ten ♪ in the second, the left has eight demisemiquavers and then thirteen in the second bar, all at a dizzying tempo!

Theme B reappears at bar 235 a fifth higher than at the start of this section.

What follows here is almost the same (twenty bars), comprising theme B and the arpeggios descending and rising in both hands, but on other degrees.

Section 5 : (from bar 256)

We arrive at this passage, which is a development of theme C (heard for the first time at bar 94), recalling Spanish music (influence of the guitar) and placed in G♯ major. The melody is in a Spanish mode on a dominant pedal of C♯ minor, with chromatic parallel thirds in the left hand serving as harmonies.

The Spanish mode (of Arab origin) is this:



Themes B and D are also heard in this section, juxtaposed. This is where:

B : bar 268 (its first part, then its second part, incomplete, at bar 271). There is a second appearance, fragmented and also incomplete, but in a lower register.

D : bar 276 (remember this is the theme with the iambs!). Here only the start is heard, with the double passing note E-C♯ but no outcome. There is the same thing at bars 289 and 303.

Our theme C, at bar 277, is in G major with, as at the start of this section, the parallel chromatic thirds serving as harmonies, but here a semitone down.

At bar 285 comes a new gesture in double notes in the right hand against chords in the left:



This quadruple appoggiatura (derived from Golaud's theme in *Pelléas*) gives rise to the gesture:



In bars 289 and 303 the iambic call of theme D flashes out from descending arpeggios on +6 chords.

Theme C is played again at bar 291 in E major and at bar 305 on a dominant seventh on B♭ with a more charged presentation. Further enriched, too, is the gesture in octaves and alternating chords in both hands that follows at bar 309. The melody is shared between the thumbs: see the *Fête Dieu à Séville* (El Corpus Christi) from Albéniz's *Iberia*.

Section 6 : (from bar 314)

This is made to develop theme A:



The melodic formula is new for this theme, except for the first three notes, which are as in the introduction.

There follows at bar 318 a short commentary, almost furtive, as if in an aside: this is theme C.

Continuation of theme A:



followed by a tiny commentary, just a iamb: the start of theme D.

Theme A explodes with greater vehemence at bar 325, with a bunch of arpeggios encompassing the whole keyboard. During the mute (the F♯), a 'rocket group' in the right hand, a ten-hemi-demisemiquaver diminuendo, dissolves in the extreme treble.

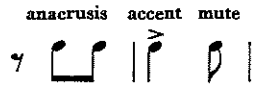
Once more the little bar commenting on this explosion refers to theme B.

Theme A continues at bar 331, still with two accents. The little commentary on theme C comprises two bars.

Yet again theme A comes back, in the middle register at bar 337, but it is cut off by theme C, also in the middle register and also in G minor.

At bar 341 theme A continues, followed by the continuation of theme C suggesting E♭ major, with a +6 chord on F plus the added sixth. In bar 342 G is strongly marked – the theme's accent on a chord in the treble – before the mute on D.

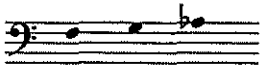
The rhythm of theme A begins to hasten at bar 345, becoming ever more exasperated through four appearances:



with the addition of numerous appoggiaturas above and below, and of 'rocket groups' towards the treble, very rapid, on the third quaver of each bar.

Theme C takes its revenge and prepares a kind of stretto to carry section 7 into the treble and up to ***ff***.

Theme C thus begins with its first three notes:



at bar 353

and increases these to four notes:



which become triple notes through two octaves in each hand, presented in a very charged manner, out of which comes the rising crescendo that produces this melodic turn (bars 362-365):



Section 7 Un peu retenu (A little slowed down)

'...the dwarf would grow and grow, from me to the moon, like the belltower of a Gothic cathedral...'

Here theme D bursts out ***ff***, then theme A is expanded, bringing back the introduction.

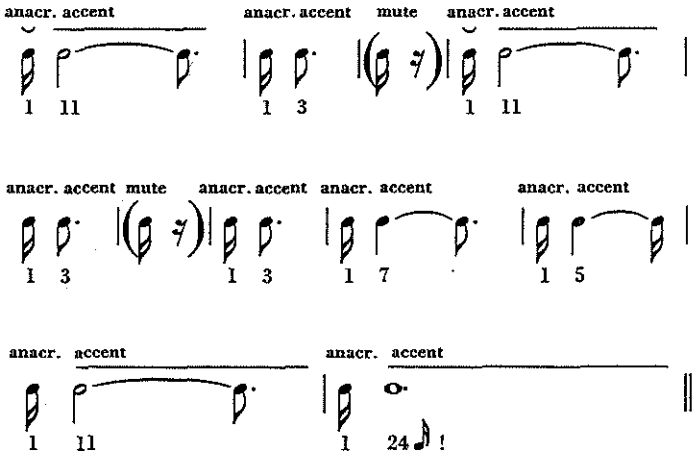
First, theme D. It bursts forth in C major, through this Franckian progression:



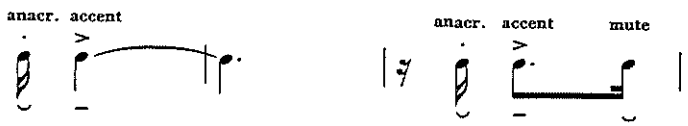
$\frac{6}{4}$ and $\frac{7}{5}$ with alteration of the 3rd (see Franck's Symphony and *Variations symphoniques*)

The iambic rhythm of this theme D continues to unfold through extreme values, very short and very long.

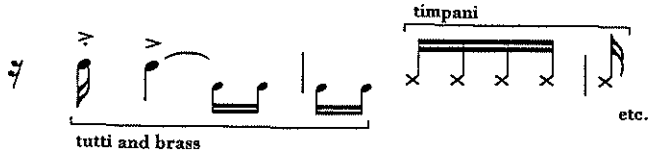
From bar 366 we have, in numbers of semiquavers:



The analysis is similar all through to that made with respect to the passage from bar 168 in section 3. As a reminder, here are the first three bars of this section (bars 366-368):



The piano writing implies the orchestra, as in the first two bars of this section (bars 366-367):



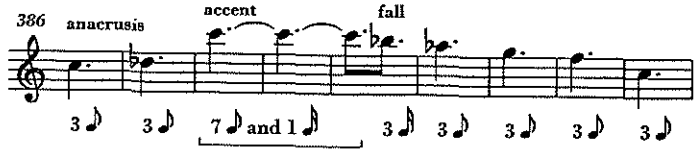
From bar 372 the iambic figure travels through five different registers, ever lower, producing an effect of going down into the depths (as at bar 204), the long value increasing the further one drives into the blackness: 3 𝅘𝅥𝅯, 7 𝅘𝅥𝅯, 5 𝅘𝅥𝅯, 11 𝅘𝅥𝅯, 24 𝅘𝅥𝅯

At bar 382 comes a bass drum roll on C-D♭, (very low trill, crescendo), swollen by the upward steps of register.

> '...Scarbo is the one who cuts my throat, and who, to cauterize my bleeding wound, plunges his finger of red-hot iron into the furnace!'
>
> Aloysius Bertrand (*La Chambre gothique*)

Over this trill, theme A enters in augmentation (see its first appearance at bar 32), in trombone register for the first three notes.

The values are considerably extended:



Just after the accent a B♭ fixes itself in the bass, followed by an ascending rocket which establishes B♭ minor with the perfect chord. The last C at the end of the fall remains in suspense, for we are back at the reprise of the introduction. It is midnight.

Section 8 : (Moderato, three times slower than the previous section)

After the explosion of theme A, here it comes back in its original register, the extreme bass. At the time Ravel composed this piece, pianos did not go down beyond A♮, even so, he wanted this theme in a black, subterranean register. The illusion of doubling in octaves is produced thus:



A timpani roll follows, as at the start, on D♯, the dominant of G♯ minor.

Three times this theme A is presented just by its first three notes, with its roll and pause.

This interruption of the drum roll produces an effect of terror, of dread. The gesture stops. There is nothing.

No, he is not there, not hidden, not under the bed...

There is no-one.

Yet he is there?

Three notes dragged, very slow...

A trembling...

A silence...

Did someone knock?

A subterranean rumbling, hardly audible, with weak eddies, confirms a phantasmal presence, like a shadow lengthening, rising with almost no sound.

'And Scarbo was in my cellar obliviously minting ducats and florins in time with the pendulum.'

Aloysius Bertrand (*Le Fou*)

With the dynamic level consistently ***ppp*** we arrive at the middle register without losing the mysterious atmosphere, and here, at bar 430, section 9 begins.

Section 9

This comprises an augmentation of theme B and a rise in seconds.

'And from the shadowy crypt...where I laid you down against the wall, you will hear at leisure little children weeping in the limbs.'

Aloysius Bertrand (first *Scarbo*)

'...the nurse who sings a monotonous lullaby to a stillborn child in my father's breastplate...'

Aloysius Bertrand (*La Chambre gothique*)

The background or this section is based on five notes moving back and forth:



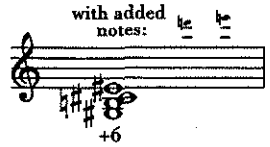
at a ***ppp***, a little monotonous, muffled, drowned by the pedal.

Theme B enters in augmentation (quavers at a slow tempo instead of fast semiquavers, as at the theme's first appearance, at bar 52). Perhaps one could say that the original speed for this theme was one bar per second and that here the augmentation produces a speed of one note (♪) per

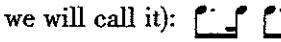
second. Theme B arrives in the second bar above the background, « *un peu marqué* » (a little marked) but claimed by the pedal and portato.

At bar 433 theme B continues, still in augmentation. Here the two descending fourths – D♯-A♯ and, in the following bar, C♯-G♯ – convey a special poetic effect, because they are slower and because of the doubling of the melody at the octave above (see the moonlight scene in Massenet's *Werther*). Such doubling of the melody happens frequently in Debussy.

In bar 435 the first trilled chord is essentially a +6 :



Next comes an arpeggio alternating between the hands, the whole giving a bitonal chord of A major and C♯ major (bar 436).

The following bar (437) sees a reprise of the rhythm from bar 65 ('rhythm x' we will call it):  with the sonority of two clarinets, oboe and cor anglais, giving a ninth chord in its first inversion:

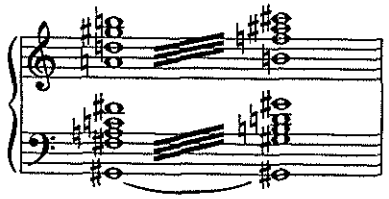


Two bars later rhythm, x is brought back, but in diminution:  (oboe and cor anglais).

7
♭3
♭3
G♮ an arpeggio on this chord rises, with appoggiaturas,

the left hand passing over the right.

Bar 439: the second trilled chord. (See the end of *The Sorcerer's Apprentice* by Paul Dukas; see also the scene of the nymph-statues in Ravel's own *Daphnis et Chloé*, where a muted orchestral quartet is heard ***ppp*** with the resonance of a tam tam.)



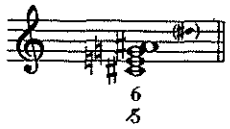
Trilled chord from the nymph-statues scene in *Daphnis et Chloé*.

The descending arpeggio, coming after this trill and alternating between the hands, is based on a ninth chord used in *Pelléas*:



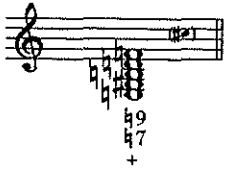
The following chord rises back (harp-like writing) at bar 441 on F♯: $^{\flat 9}_{7}$ with the added major sixth, D♯. This envelops theme B, proceeding still in augmentation, whose continuation is doubled across three octaves in bars 443-444.

Harmonies: bar 443:



the D♯ is an échappée

Bar 444:



the C♯ is an added major sixth

There follow three bars of transition, of music in mist, shared between the hands with the right above. See Debussy's *Cloches à travers les feuilles*.

Then comes the passage entirely in seconds (at bar 448). Ravel's love for the interval of a second is well known: see *Laideronnette, impératrice des pagodes* in *Ma Mère l'Oye*. He as a child is said to have sought out seconds at the piano, just as the child Mozart looked for thirds.

> '...and roll through the room like a spindle fallen from a witch's distaff...'

Ravel brings back the melodic turn from bar 80 (the gesture of muted violins) but here at a slow tempo in quavers, i.e. in augmentation. This motif is presented on a D pedal.

See the drowning scene in *Wozzeck*, also on a pedal. It is worth remarking how often terrifying moments in opera are expressed over a pedal... Criminal acts and murders seem to need this presence, hidden in the shadows, immobile, silently watching its prey as the drama sharpens, develops, unfolds.

In these menacing shadows, ***pp***, the seconds rise and descend within a very confined chromatic space, harmonized with major $^{6}_{4}$ chords in the left hand, wed to the same contour.

At bar 454 the pedal descends a semitone to C♯. The rhythm becomes irrational: three quavers against quintuplet semiquavers, and against normal semiquavers (hence three against five, then three against four).

The accelerando favours the rhythmic mismatch; the crescendo becomes menacing, and then a new figure begins at a ***p*** level in bar 460.

This strange and marvellous page (from bar 448 onwards) has its unavoidable gloss in Betrand's *Le Nain*:

> 'Where is your soul, for me to sit astride!...
>
> 'And my soul slid out in terror, through the pallid needlework of the twilight-time spider...
>
> 'But the dwarf, stayed in his neighing flight, rolled around like a spindle in the threads of his white mane.'

We come then to bar 460, marked: **Toujours en accélérant** (consistently accelerating). The gesture in seconds is based on the fingering: 1 [$\frac{3}{2}$ 1 [$\frac{3}{2}$ etc. (laying the thumb on its side, the $\frac{3}{2}$ fingers flat on the keyboard).

Just on the black keys the left hand plays an arpeggio alongside a rising gesture in the right hand, still with the $\frac{3}{2}$ fingers and the thumb, in bars 468-472.

Then comes an admirable and redoubtable descent, through chords of the whole-tone scale in its two transpositions.

In the right hand $\frac{3}{2}$ flat on black keys and 1 [thumb laid down on white keys. The gesture is of semiquavers descending two by two at a steep angle from the extreme treble to the extreme bass. The left hand follows the movement but with broken major thirds and in quavers (the right hand having continuous semiquavers).

Having reached the low register we find, at bar 477,

Section 10

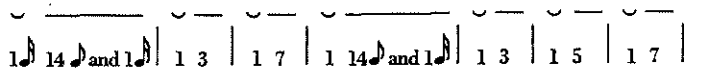
This is the development of theme D (the main theme, iambic). It leads to a new ***fff*** presentation of this theme – indeed, an explosion of it – at bar 563.

The characteristic of theme D is, as before, its iambic rhythm (iamb: ⏑ – short-long) expressed in three different ways: as a 𝅘𝅥𝅯 short unit and a very long long that becomes less so (from 14 𝅘𝅥𝅯 and 1 𝅘𝅥𝅯 and 17 𝅘𝅥𝅯 and 1 𝅘𝅥𝅯 |, to 5 𝅘𝅥𝅯 and 1 𝅘𝅥𝅯 | as a semi-

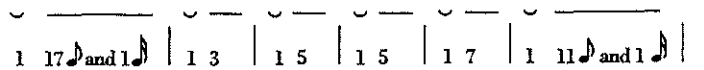
quaver short followed by a long of 3, 4, 5 or 7 𝅘𝅥𝅯) and finally as a group of shorts and longs forming a feminine rhythm of anacrusis-accent-fall (or mute).

Here then are the rhythms of bars 477-579, just in numbers (the very long long is indicated by a long line: ——)

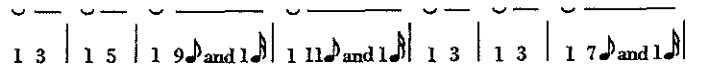
From bar 477:



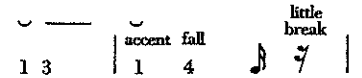
From bar 492:



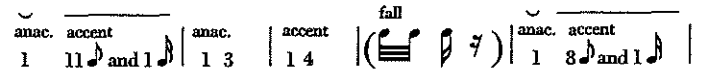
From bar 506:



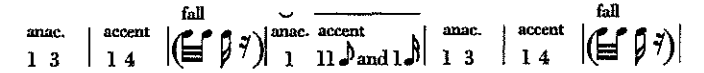
From bar 519:



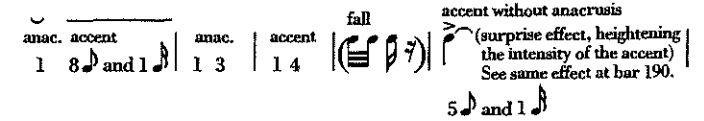
From bar 521:



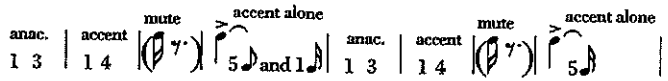
Mes. 530 :



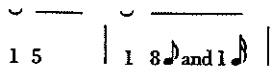
Mes. 538 :



From bar 545:



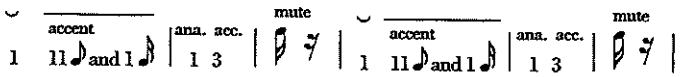
From bar 552:



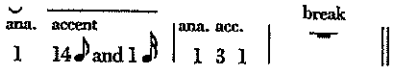
From bar 556: long, seven-bar rise in anacruses on:



At bar 563, at the marking **Un peu moins vif** (a little less fast), the iambs begin again, ***fff***.



From bar 573:



Let us return to the start of this section, at bar 477. The threefold strokes in the extreme bass and the F♯ pedal produce an atmosphere of dread on which the iambs impose their short-circuits. In order to encash, or furnish, the long values, arpeggios descend four times. But from bar 521 (value of eleven ♪ and one 𝅘𝅥𝅯) the gestures rise in a crescendo like a sudden assault for two bars. One finds the gesture of bar 523 in the second act of Paul Dukas's *Ariane et Barbe-Bleue*.

The main theme D finds its definitive form in bar 521. It is preceded by a break of a 𝄾 rest – very short, like a guillotine. We are in F minor. Anacrusis of a 𝅘𝅥𝅯, and accent swollen by the

sudden assault rising at a crescendo, which might recall a string quartet. Later, at bar 532, the key becomes B♭ minor. If we examine the gesture in simple notes at bars 539-540 we may admire just how Ravel gives it stuffing (or makes it swell).

The rise here is made in octaves and chords alternating between the hands, the thumbs giving this melodic turn:



Now comes the long rise in anacruses drawn in each case from the same gesture. It is played by the left hand with expansion of intervals, from minor seconds to ninths.

The first notes of each bar in the bass produce the complete second 'mode of limited transpositions'. In the rallentando the left hand adds in a seventh semiquaver. As for the right hand, it repeats this rhythm seven times:



And here comes B major glorifying this iambic theme D at bar 563, **Un peu moins vif** (a little less fast). Perfect chord of B major.

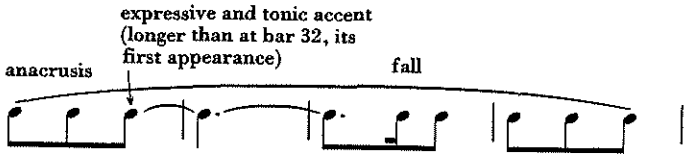
> '...the dwarf would grow and grow, from me to the moon, like the belltower of a Gothic cathedral...'

To give the sensation of a growing, in the density of the chord, there are gestures in octaves weighted with three-note chords in each hand rising at a crescendo three times. The impression is of a furious, inundating wave, of the tutti of an organ which in two seconds pulls out all the stops. Break of

one bar – an abrupt break after three *ff* chords. What will happen? Ravel's genius answers by having theme A (not heard for a long time) burst out at a reduced tempo, surrounded by a spray of arpeggios going in every direction, like a pianistic firework display. This is how the eleventh and last section of this extraordinary work begins.

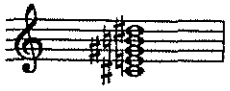
Section 11

We thus have, at bar 580, theme A, analysed as usual:



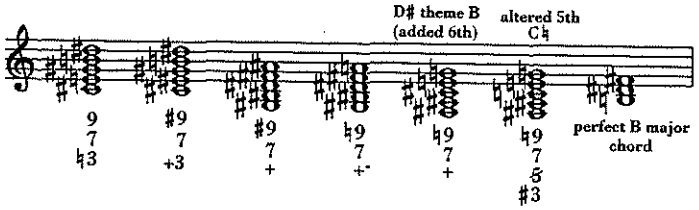
This section comprises the recapitulation of themes A and B, and the Coda. (Music analogous to sections 2 and 1.) The piece ends in B major.

At bar 580 comes the ninth chord, the chord Ravel loved particularly and which, one may note, he used at his moments of great emotion:



(see the last piece of *Ma Mère l'Oye*, *Daphnis*, *Le Tombeau de Couperin*, etc.)

Little outline of the chords in this last section:



Let us go back a little...

'His face would pale...'

The French word here means 'become blue'.

At bar 586 a little iamb, the start of theme D, is a discreet recollection. Then at bar 592 the F♯ establishes itself in the bass (dominant of B major). Theme B arrives in augmentation, again in two parts and remaining incomplete. All the themes lose their energy and little by little their personality.

Theme D appears at bar 602, but without conviction, showing only two notes: a start barely glimpsed, remaining in suspense. All drives into the night and the bass.

> '...his face would pale like the wax of a taper – and suddenly he had gone out.'

And so we have come to the end of Scarbo, and it is on this B natural, the tonic of B major, hardly audible, played in the extreme bass and *pp* (bar 615), that one senses the disappearance of the main character.

'He had gone out...'

All that remains is a discreet shimmering: a high trill on the perfect chord of B major (with a C𝄪 appoggiatura to the D♯) and a little eulogy to Scarbo in the form of the first three notes of his theme A, left in suspense. The trill shades off, descending furtively into the night. Last homage: a little echo pirouette for Scarbo and his mischief, an arpeggio in the last bar between the hands based on a bitonal chord:



and ending with the second so dear to Ravel: 

LE TOMBEAU DE COUPERIN

(Couperin's Memorial)

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LE TOMBEAU DE COUPERIN

(Couperin's Memorial)
by Maurice Ravel

No-one who was there could fail to remember dearly the analyses Olivier Messiaen made in his class at the Paris Conservatoire on the works of Ravel: *Ma Mère l'Oye*, *Daphnis et Chloé*, *Miroirs*, the *Histoires naturelles* (Natural Histories), the *Valses nobles et sentimentales*, etc. Pierre Boulez has said that his first encounter with Messiaen was at an analysis of *Ma Mère l'Oye*. More than fifty years later he remembers his astonishment at the musical poetry his teacher revealed, while bringing to light the formal ideas, the technical skills in matters of orchestration and instrumentation, the thoroughly personal melodic formulae.

Le Tombeau de Couperin is a homage to François Couperin (1668-1733), who created a new way of writing for the harpsichord with his individual idea of making little pictures that depicted people's features (virtues and faults), such as La Fontaine described in his fables.

The keyboard writing is also new in its repeated notes, its ornaments, its diverse attacks.

In Ravel's *Le Tombeau de Couperin* there is reference to aspects of 'modality', 'old France', forgotten dances, popular themes, 'simple songs', sad stories like faded roses (one thinks of the theme of the Fugue, with its chopped subject,

broken with sighs, like the songs of the troubadours...). So many technical discoveries in gestures covering all the piano's registers!

So much harmonic research! Embroideries of chords, turning chromatically around a perfect triad – not forgetting the palpable modesty with which Ravel allows a glimpse of a neutral seventh or ninth chord. He stays on the edge of the picture and dreams of the castle into which he dare not enter...

1. Prelude

Four faces of the music:
A – Background theme
B – Passage in chromatic harmonies
C – Second theme, arpeggiated
D – Formula with ground note, ornamented, leading towards a cadence

This prelude is short, lively in tempo and lasts only two and a half minutes.

Summary of the form:
A – Background theme
B – Chromatic passage
C – Second theme, arpeggiated
D – Formula with ground note leading towards a cadence in G (the relative major)

Then
A – Background theme
C – Second theme, arpeggiated

A – Background theme
C – Second theme, arpeggiated
B – Chromatic passage (with a new accompanying melodic motif) in two sections
C – Second theme, arpeggiated
D – Formula with ground note, ornamented, leading towards the final cadence

Coda: Background theme A and descent on its first four notes, followed by a pentatonic re-ascent leading to the trilled final chord of a new neutral ninth.

Details

A – The background theme is airy. The melodic curve is made of seconds descending and rising ~~~ and two rising thirds. It is in the Aeolian mode on E:



At bar 10 the background is played by the left hand and in the dominant, B.

B – Passage in chromatic harmonies from bar 14. In its upper voice the left hand has:



The harmonies may be represented by these figurings over the left hand's lower part (also chromatic):

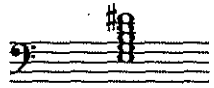


The right hand embroiders the harmonies with sextuplet semiquavers, in seconds and fifths.

C – In bar 22 the second theme enters with its arpeggio, on notes 3-6 of the background theme, with expanded intervals. It is in quavers and dotted crotchets, giving it a more expansive and lyrical feeling.

D – At bar 26 comes the formula with the ornamented ground note (or inverted pedal) – here F♯ – moving towards the cadence in the relative major, G (bar 30).

Bar 28: the 'Ravel ninth':



After the repeat we find, at bar 34, A – the background theme, with the two poles C and F.

At bar 38 there appears the second theme, C, this time modulating from C through B♭ to a cadence in D major (dominant of the relative major), which is found at bar 44.

Bar 45: A – background theme in D, then C.

C – The second theme reappears at bar 50 with new harmonies: augmented fifth and dominant seventh chords. It modulates in descending whole tones.

Bar 56: major ninth on G♯.

B – At bar 58 the passage in chromatic harmonies comes back, in two sections, the second beginning at bar 63. But a new melodic motif accompanies it in dotted crotchets – in

seconds and thirds - moving at first towards D major, then towards A♭ major.

C – This theme returns at bar 68. It modulates by way of D (bar 73) to reach the F♯ top-note, then the B top-note and finally the cadence in E.

The harmonies are simple:

5	5	#_____	5_____	#_____
D	C	B A	G F♮	E D

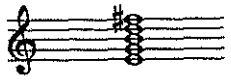
and at bar 77 the rise on the neutral ninth.

After this arrival in the piano's top register, a great descent is made in diminuendo on the neutral seventh. The gesture is composed of fourteen cells (rising second and falling third). The cadence is in modal E, at bar 83.

The Coda begins from this bar. It is based on the background theme, oscillating between the tonic E and D in the same mode, the E remaining an inverted pedal. Again there is a descent into the bass on the first four notes of the background theme.

At bar 90 comes a pianissimo point of repose on the tonic E in the extreme bass.

Is the bouquet lacking a long stem? Here it comes: a spray lifts off like a harp glissando from the bass to the treble, in pentatonic mode, towards the final chord. This is a trilled modal chord in root position, a neutral ninth:



And the piece ends on this quivering tinted a little with the past.

2. Fugue

Since all the pieces in *Le Tombeau de Couperin* are dedicated to friends killed during the 1914-18 war, one might perhaps imagine Ravel wanting, in his only fugue (the only fugue in his entire output), to reunite these people he had loved, and so create a kind of multiplied presence drawn from the one theme, which is repeated twenty-two times.

This subject is sad in expression, its motifs interrupted by silences.

Ravel added to it a counter-subject opposed in character: legato, expressive, touching, consoling, calming.

It is exceedingly conjunct, with a perfect fourth as final jump.

Analysis

The theme is a plaintive motif, like repeated tears looking for consolation. The rhythm is reduced to two or three equal notes. The first note is accented, the second or third left dry. The effect is thus of little groans, one after another with semiquaver rests in between. Despair here is a little sucked in, not overstepping the range of a fifth.

This is a fugue of classical build, modal for the most part, but including many strettos on the counter-subject. It is for three voices, admirably laid out with crossings of voices, presenting the subject in original shape and inversion (or contrary motion), all in equal values, and having recourse only twice to a *f* dynamic. It is a fugue preserving the intimacy of a memory behind lowered curtains, of a prayer with eyes closed.

The exposition of the subject is followed by its response at bar 3. As usual the counter-subject enters with the response. The subject follows immediately (entry of the third voice). It has no response, but the subject is expressed again in the middle voice, which has its response at bar 11.

A little transition of two bars from bar 13 leads the subject to G (the relative major) at bar 15 and to D at bar 17.

The first episode, at bar 19, is constructed on the counter-subject with three entries.

Then we see our subject inverted in the middle voice and in contrary motion at bar 22 (instead of descending it rises!). In turn its response is also inverted.

Then comes the second episode, again having recourse to the counter-subject, but here in two directions, normal and contrary.

At bar 30 one comes to a cadence on the dominant, from which, on a B pedal, begins a stretto on the beginning of the subject with a stretto on that of the counter-subject. Still on a sustained B, bar 35 sets out a subject and its response, followed by a stretto on the counter-subject.

The subject appears again in contrary motion at bar 39: in the bass with a canon at the tenth in the upper voice, followed by the counter-subject in its original form and twice in contrary motion. A parenthetical bar (43) starts a subject without continuing it, for at bar 44 the subject arrives in normal and contrary forms simultaneously. The tonality touches the A minor (subdominant of the principal key of E).

A new stretto for the counter-subject in normal and contrary forms gets under way at bar 46, leading to the subject at bar 48, also in normal and contrary forms, which again are presented simultaneously.

At bar 50 we find a descent on the start of the subject in normal and contrary motion. This is the first cadence (there will be three) on the keynote: E. An E pedal is implied at bar 54, where another stretto on the counter-subject in contrary motion begins. The second (modal) cadence in E at bar 56 is followed by the completion of the stretto on the counter-subject.

We then come to the third cadence in E (in the treble) at bar 58. The tempo relaxes and, as in a casket, the subject appears three times over in canon at a distance of a quaver. Pearls brought together in one piece of jewellery!

Then comes the farewell, at a slow tempo and with a further rallentando. It takes the consolatory and calming form of the counter-subject's song in a threefold stretto at two crotchet's distance, closing the piece in the Aeolian mode.

3. Forlane[1]

The forlane is a dance in 6/8 which originated in Friuli[2] and in Venice, and which was very popular at the start of the seventeenth century.

The form is simple:

1) Refrain
2) First verse (in E minor)
3) Refrain
4) Second verse (in B minor, the dominant)
5) Refrain (en canon)
6) Coda (or verse, in the major)

1) Refrain

Theme of eight bars, divided at the halfway point.

From the second bar, on its first beat, we have the 'Pelléas chord': G♯ major on A major:



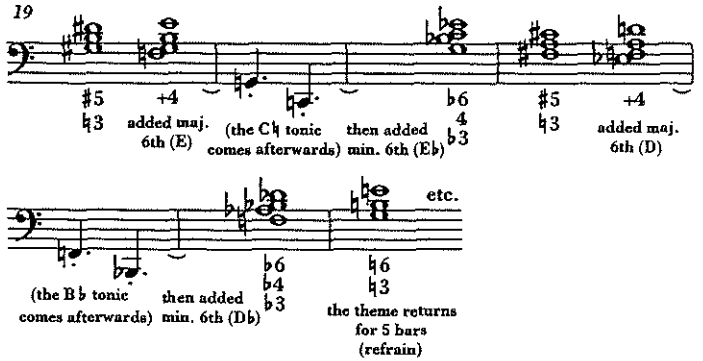
This is the accent prepared by the anacrusis on the first beat of bar 1. At the start of bar 5 the cadence is elided into the anacrusis.

1) Analysis by Olivier Messiaen after his piano score
2) Friuli: Italian province

The first period of the commentary, consisting of ten bars, begins at bar 9.

In this bar, besides the 'Pelléas chord', we have a B♮ that is an anticipation of the following chord, a dominant ninth on C♯ in the bass.

The second period of the commentary, starting at bar 19, comprises twice three bars. It is a harmonic march:



2) First verse

The first verse begins on the second beat of bar 29. It is in E minor (the main key) and lasts for eight bars. Its characteristic is a burst of seconds on each beat, and its melodic turn is composed of a second and a fourth – F♯-E-B, as at the start of the first movement, the Prelude – setting out from a ninth chord with lowered third. E in the bass. The chord of E minor sways in the bass, while the melodic turn descends in four stages.

In bar 30 the mode is Dorian (E minor with C♯). The commentary starts at bar 37 (after the repeat) and consists of twice four bars. It touches B major, F♯ major, D♯ major and again F♯ major before bringing back the beginning of the first verse in E minor.

3) Refrain

This starts at bar 53 and lasts for eight bars. There is an elision in the ninth bar with the entry of the second verse.

4) Second verse

The second verse (in B minor, the dominant tonality) begins at bar 61. It comprises twice four bars and leads to a chord of E major for its commentary (bar 69). We move through E minor, D minor and C major towards a dominant pedal on F♯. At bar 77 we have the second 'mode of limited transpositions' over this dominant pedal of B minor up to the reprise of the second verse at bar 85, which again lasts eight bars, since the reprise of the refrain starts at bar 93.

5) Refrain

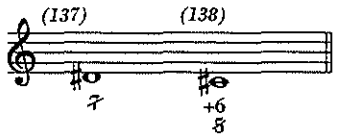
The left hand responds in canon from bar 97 up to the commentary (bar 101), which is an exact repeat of the music heard before the first verse (bars 9-29).

6) Coda

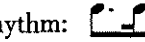
The Coda, or verse in the major, begins at bar 121. Eight luminous bars in E, with brass-type chords in superimposed thirds – up to six of them (bar 126).

There follows a commentary on a harmonic march from bar 129, in the form of cadences disguised by added notes. Other cadential formulae appear from bar 137 onwards.

Chords:



Bar 139 includes passing fifths (see Gluck's *Armide*). The right hand plays equal quavers, a little meowed (think of *L'Enfant et les sortilèges*).

Bars 149-153: $\frac{7}{+}$ $\frac{7}{+}$ two dominant sevenths and still the cadential formulae. A recollection of the refrain and its characteristic rhythm:  followed by a chord giving the whole-tone scale at bar 154 on the first beat. The B on the second beat provides the explanation: this is a $\frac{7}{+}$ chord with major ninth, minor sixth and augmented fourth.

The following bar presents $\frac{7}{+}$: in another aspect, with minor ninth, major sixth and augmented fourth.

The start of the refrain (with its rhythm) rises in three stages and gets lost in the treble. An open fifth, E-B, ends the piece, which is a harmonic masterpiece. On these two notes – simple and neutral, a little sad, unsigned by a major or minor third – the music disappears without a trace of rallentando, towards an evocation of the middle ages.

4. Rigaudon

The rigaudon is a lively duple-time dance of Provençal origin, which was in fashion in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. It was named after the dancing master Rigaud.

The form here is simple, being basically an ABA:

A: key of C major

B: middle section in C minor with a new theme

A: reprise of the opening in C major

Now to the detail:

A: The beginning is an arrow-cadence theme, the cadence chord being without leading note and containing piled thirds. Arrows rise and descend in the right hand, with a percussive effect as of a Provençal tambourin (small drum) in the left

hand with double stops on the cello. At the end of bar 2 there follows the first theme, which is conjunct, made of three notes and a return, and played by the right hand:



The left hand plays 'sheep jumps' over the right, with chords descending towards the bass and a pedal G above the right hand.

At bar 8 come two arrow themes and then the first theme played in the left hand. At bar 13 there is a modal cadence in C (Mixolydian mode). The theme then comes back again after the arrow theme in B♭ major in bar 16. At bar 20 comes a cadence in C♯ major followed by an arrow theme in F♯ major. From bar 25 there begins a development of the first theme towards the conclusion of the first part.

B: The middle section begins at the marking **Moins vif**, (less fast, bar 37). A new theme (i.e. the second theme) is introduced, in C minor, evoking a solo oboe accompanied by pizzicato strings. This is a swaying accompaniment, between pairs of even quavers in different registers. There is therefore a regular frame for the numerous anapaests (∪ ∪ _) of the melody. The fourth bar has two:



The theme has its antecedent (a) at bar 37 and its consequent (b) at bar 53.

There is a cadence on the dominant at bar 66.

The middle section of the middle section, (c), beginning at bar 69, is a modulating passage, ***pp***. The solo suggests a somewhat hoarse timbre: one might imagine the oboe having a

mute... The harmonies are simple: in bars 72-76 and 77-81 perfect chords and sevenths, leading to cadences at first in G♯ major, then in F♯ major. There is a point of repose lasting four bars, with a hold through eight crotchets on the tonic of F♯ major.

From bar 85, in subsection (d), Ravel expresses his feeling in a touching new phrase in octaves, modulating from F♯ minor to C major by way of E minor, E modal and D major.

A: The return of C major takes place at bar 93. For twenty-four bars the opening of the piece is repeated exactly.

The final development on the first theme begins at the end of bar 116. It borrows from the keys of E, D, C and F before ending in the initial key of C major with the arrow-cadence theme, accompanied as ever by the suggestion of the Provençal tambourin and cello double stops.

5. Minuet[1]

The minuet is a stately dance for couples, with reverences, dating from the eighteenth century. Its rhythm is ternary (3/4), with little steps and slightly precious gestures: extending the fingertips and pointing the toes. Phrases are normally of four or eight bars.

The form is marked by a middle section which is a musette in the minor, followed by the reprise of the opening in the major, marrying the first theme and the musette, this time in major dress.

First part: periods A, B and C

A: First period of eight bars with the first segment of the theme, in seconds, having a lower appoggiatura.

1) Analysis by Olivier Messiaen after his piano score

The second segment is more disjunct, coming to rest on the dominant of the relative minor.

B: Commentary, of eight bars. The theme is transposed and joined to eight more bars, towards a cadence in the dominant key of D (end of the second period).

Bars 17-18: ninth chords with lowered third, on G♮ and then D♮.

The second-fourth motif, E-D-A, in bars 19-20, is immediately repeated in contrary motion as B-C♯-F♯ (rising).

C: The third period, of eight bars ending in G (tonic), begins at bar 25, with the theme transposed yet again. At bar 30 the ninth chord with lowered third reappears.

Second part

This is the trio, in the minor. The melody of this musette is set on a pedal fifth, G-D. It is in the Dorian mode on G, i.e. G minor with E♮.

The pedal fifth swaying through four octaves is a homage to Rameau (see the *Musette en Rondeau*).

Period A: eight bars with some attractive melodic turns:

Bars 35-37:



Bars 38-40:



where we find again (as already in the first bar of this piece) the rising seconds Ravel favoured. The whole melody is composed of perfect chords. At bar 41 the preceding eight bars are repeated, with the pedals G-D and D-D embracing the musette theme like lianas.

The commentary (on a G tonic pedal) begins at bar 49 (see Bizet's *L'Arlésienne*). A crescendo through eight bars brings the dramatic tension to its peak at bar 57 in a ***ff*** on the chord of D♭ major, followed by chromatic perfect chords in a diminuendo towards the reprise of the theme of period A of the musette, appearing this time without its repetition.

Third part: the 'recapitulation'

The first theme (period A) returns in the treble, in dialogue with the musette theme in the middle register, but 'majorized'. This procedure is not always a success, and one may note that the great composers often preferred to change the intervals of a 'majorized' theme. Here the effect is of winter turned to spring, and made more ravishing by the poetry of the initial major theme.

It is a little like a musical snowdrop...

The resting place on the dominant of the relative minor returns at the eighth bar. Period B of the first part then has its commentary transposed a third up: instead of ending in D major, this period B concludes in F♯ major.

Period C, at bar 97, again starting with a three-bar phrase, has these three bars slightly altered in their harmonies, but the cadence is still in G major (bar 104).

The Coda, at bar 105, develops the second segment of the first theme, and at bar 111 brings back the first theme in long values, with its opening embroidery of the second beneath. The B now is a semibreve (four crotchets) three times, then a minim. It is first a seventh (seventh chord on C), then a ninth (ninth chord with lowered third on A). Three calm dotted minims prepare the tonic pedal, and the beginning of the first theme descends as if down three landings.

At bar 125 come two fifths on a $\frac{9}{7}{}_{4}$ chord (fourth instead of leading note), and the following perfect chord, in superposed thirds, has a double trill on the third and the fifth, a touch of evanescence.

6. Toccata

A toccata is an instrumental piece of brilliant character, most often written for keyboard instruments (piano, organ, harpsichord). It is almost always of redoubtable virtuosity: pianists have a healthy fear of Schumann's Toccata, of Prokofiev's – and also of Ravel's. Nor are organists happy when the bride's mother asks for Widor's toccata as recessional at the marriage service – especially if there are plenty of people, because then it will have to be played twice, which is really tiring if the organ is not electrified!

This Toccata by Ravel, despite its brief timing of four and a half minutes, remains difficult: its tempo is rapid and there are many repeated notes that have to be clear and brilliant, not to mention numerous gestures with the hands crossing.

The piece boasts three themes:

– The first, at bar 5, is a conjunct motif
– Bridge, at bar 35, in seconds, thirds and fourths
– The second, at bar 57, is presented at the dominant with a new rhythm 
– The third, at bar 96, is a theme in very long values, on the black keys and with crossings of hands.

Semiquavers go incessantly from start to finish, requiring from the pianist an excellent repeated-note technique and great suppleness in the arms to avoid getting tense.

Here is an analysis in detail:

The initial key is E minor, the tonic E being affirmed through the first two bars. The first theme appears at bar 5, a conjunct motif in seconds.

Many pianists who knew Ravel assert that in bar 5 he allowed the two Gs in the right hand to be taken by the left, which eases execution thus:



The fragmentary motif at bar 11, x, will return.

At bar 23 we are already in the relative major, G. The first theme is presented in G major, then B♭ major.

At bar 35 comes the bridge theme, in seconds and thirds. (It has to be called a theme because it is brought back, and developed in stages and through modulations, from bar 191 onwards.) Its first presentation here is in C major, followed by B minor and then by that key's dominant, F♯, at bar 42.

F♯ is affirmed through fifteen bars, with an appoggiatura chord of +6 on B. See bar 105 of *Alborada del gracioso* (The Fool's Aubade) from *Miroirs*, where one finds this same chord:



There it seems to be an embroidery around the F♯, a tremulous shadowing of its resonance.

Four bars, from bar 53, bring a rise on F♯-A-C♯-E (seventh chord) introducing the second theme, which arrives at the marking « **Un peu moins vif** » (a little less fast) and has the form

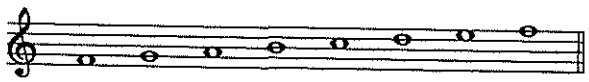
of a scalewise descent through a fifth. It is in the new rhythm of  and B minor, the dominant of the main key. This theme is eventually 'glorified' in E major, ***ff***, at bar 221; we will call it the second theme (a).

In the third bar (59) we find the typically Ravelian melodic turn from the very first bar of *Ma Mère l'Oye*:

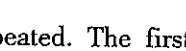


(second and fifth).

Immediately after this comes a second aspect of the theme, which we will call second theme (b), because from bar 63 it rises, always in the same dotted rhythm  , to reach the key of C major and then F Lydian:



reaching by the relationship of an augmented fourth (F♮-B♮) the key of B minor, which is the dominant of the initial E minor.

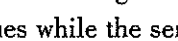
Bars 81-86: affirmation of B, repeated. The first theme appears again in the bass at bar 86. By way of a seventh chord on D♯ we climb back to the treble. This D♯ minor is a strange key, but Ravel chooses it because of his third theme, which he presents on the black keys. This theme is in long values:  while its encasing is in semiquavers. The layout is for crossed hands: the left hand plays the theme and the right passes below with its thirds. It traverses the keys of D♯ minor, C♯ minor and, for the cadence, C♯ major.

The first theme, in the bass from bar 122, modulates from C♯ to A.

At bar 130 comes a seventh chord on E♯ as before at bar 94) to rise back towards another phrase of the third theme. The

layout is changed: now the right hand plays the theme in long values while the semiquavers are no longer on the black keys and the hands are no longer crossed.

The theme comes to an unexpected end on the chord of a sixth and a diminished fifth on F♯, which reverses the sharps. F♯ is the dominant's dominant.

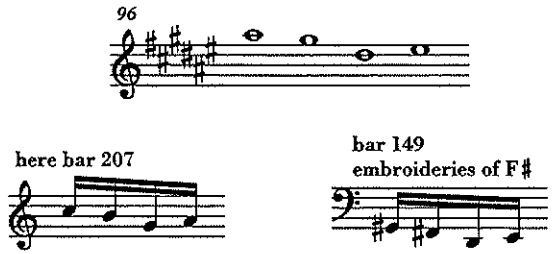
Affirmation of F♯ with a curving embroidery  of G♯, F♯, D, E at bar 149, then first theme.

At bar 155 comes a short incursion of the third theme, making its first appeal. Then the whole process begins again: embroidery of F♯ from bar 162, first theme, then the third theme making its second appeal, a little longer.

Fragment x from the first theme (see bar 11) returns at bar 173.

At bar 181 the first theme, in the bass, appears on a dominant $\frac{9}{7}$ chord, then on a chord of the fourth and sixth of G major.

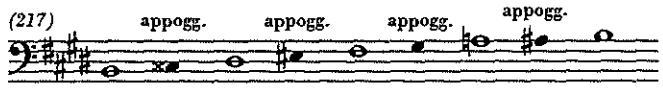
The development of the bridge theme (first heard at bar 35) appears at bar 191. Ravel notates it in long values and legato phrases, marked « *en dehors* » (in relief). It modulates, becomes louder and makes its way towards the dominant. Having reached the treble and a ***ff*** dynamic level, it struggles with itself on the motif C-B-G-A, which is a formula from the third theme in diminution and with narrowed intervals, proclaimed by the thumbs. The shape of the motif is V with the return ¯ – _ –



The first theme is back again at bar 213: see bar 5.

The pause in bar 216 is rather a suspension of time in order to draw breath!

Now comes a crescendo rise from the bass to the treble on a dominant seventh chord with appoggiaturas:



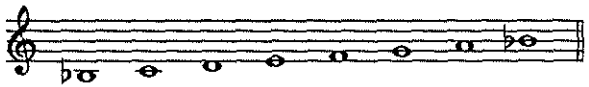
This surging introduces the second theme in glory, and in E major. It retains its distinctive rhythm, as at its first presentation at bar 57:



First comes its (a) section and then, at bar 227, its (b). The rhythm is brought into a stretto in bars 231-232:



At bar 234 comes an F major surprise entry of the third theme in diminution (as before at bar 207), played by the two thumbs. Then the tonality is B♭ Lydian (i.e. with augmented fourth:



Through the relationship B♭-E♮ (as at bar 78, where there was the same connection, F-B) E major bursts in at bar 244 in the form of its perfect chord, ***fff*** in the treble, descending like an arrow into the bass in a single bar.

The writing for the right hand at bar 245 recalls Chopin's in his *Ballades* (especially the third), having a three-note chord balanced by the thumb, with return. In the left hand the difficulty resides in the fifth E-B, where the fourth would seem easier. Final bar: supremacy of the major third, G♯, the jewel in the crown of E major.